14 DEVOTIONALS ON MICAH

Who Is a God Like You?

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How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. "Digging Deeper" takes you into the context and the language of the original text. "Living It Out" asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

Who Is a God Like You?
14 devotionals on Micah

Scripture: own translation from the Hebrew (Masoretic Text) by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Verse numbers follow the Hebrew text.

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Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/micha/en/

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DAY 1

When the Lord Comes Down from His Holy Temple

SCRIPTURE

Micah 1:1–7

1 The word of the LORD that came to Micah of Moresheth in the days of
Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah, kings of Judah, which he saw concerning
Samaria and Jerusalem.

2 Hear, you peoples, all of you!
Listen, O earth, and all that fills it!
Let the Lord, the LORD, be a witness against you,
the Lord from his holy temple.
3 For look: the LORD is coming out of his place;
he comes down and treads on the high places of the earth.
4 The mountains melt beneath him,
and the valleys split open,
like wax before the fire,
like water poured down a slope.
5 All this is for the rebellion of Jacob
and for the sins of the house of Israel.
What is the rebellion of Jacob?
Is it not Samaria?
And what are the high places of Judah?
Is it not Jerusalem?
6 So I will make Samaria a heap of rubble in the open field,
a place for planting vineyards;
I will pour her stones down into the valley
and lay bare her foundations.
7 All her carved images will be smashed,
all her wages will be burned with fire,
and all her idols I will make a desolation;
for from the wages of a prostitute she gathered them,
and to the wages of a prostitute they will return.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we begin a fourteen-day journey through the book of Micah – a journey that leads to one great question: *Who is a God like you?* (7:18).

To feel the force of Micah's opening words, we first need to stand beside him in the dusty fields of the eighth century BC. Unlike his famous contemporary Isaiah, who moved in the royal palaces and government circles of Jerusalem, **Micah was a man from the countryside.** He came from **Moresheth-gath**, a fertile farming village in the *Shephelah* (the hilly lowlands south-west of Jerusalem, some 35 to 40 kilometres from the capital, near the Philistine border).

Micah's name (Mi*kh*ah – מִיכָה, short for Mi*kh*ayah) means **Who is like the LORD (YHWH)?** His whole ministry is a living answer to that question. He was active in the reigns of Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah (about 740–686 BC) – a time of immense political upheaval, when the ruthless superpower Assyria was beginning to swallow up the ancient Near East. While the political and religious elite in the capitals, Samaria (the northern kingdom) and Jerusalem (the southern kingdom), grew rich and put their trust in military alliances and idols, the ordinary smallholders in the countryside paid the price: corrupt taxes, land-grabbing and the threat of war.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **The cosmic covenant lawsuit (*riv* – רִיב):** Micah does not open his book with gentle encouragement but with a formal court summons (the word *riv* itself appears later, in 6:1–2). The first word of verse 2, *shim'u* – שִׁמְעוּ ("*Hear!*" – listen closely!), opens each of the book's three main sections (Micah 1:2; 3:1; 6:1). All creation and all peoples are called as witnesses into a cosmic courtroom where *Adonai* YHWH – the Lord, the LORD – is not only the Judge but also the chief witness (*le'ed* – לְעֵד) against his own covenant people.

- **The wordplay on "high places" (*bamot* – בָּמוֹת):** In verses 3 and 5 Micah uses the word *bamot* with cutting irony. On the one hand, *bamotei 'arets* – בָּמֳתֵי אֶרֶץ ("the high places of the earth") are the majestic mountain peaks and military strongholds people boast in for their safety. On the other hand, *bamot* are the illegitimate pagan **shrines on the heights**, where Israel and Judah went to worship idols such as Baal and Asherah. When the Lord comes down from his holy temple (*mehekhal qodsho* – מֵהֵיכַל קָדְשׁוֹ), he treads right on top of these man-made "high places".
- **Rebellion (*pesha'* – פֶּשַׁע) and sin (*chatta't* – חַטָּאת):** Verse 5 names the people's guilt with two precise terms. *Pesha'* is not a mere slip, but **deliberate rebellion, a treacherous breach of covenant** against a loving covenant King – hence our translation "rebellion". *Chatta't* means **to miss the mark** – to stray from the purpose for which God made his people.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's holiness is never indifferent to sin.** The picture of mountains melting like soft wax (*donag* – דּוֹנַג) before the fire and of valleys splitting open (v. 4) reminds us that the Creator is not limited by his creation or by human power structures. What looks immovable and permanent to us melts away the moment God's holy presence touches it.
2. **Spiritual decay often begins at the centres of influence.** In verse 5 Micah asks two rhetorical questions: *"What is the rebellion of Jacob? Is it not Samaria? And what are the high places of Judah? Is it not Jerusalem?"* The capitals should have been fountains of justice and pure worship. Instead they became the epicentre of compromise. When leadership turns corrupt, the whole nation bleeds.
3. **What is built on spiritual unfaithfulness ends in ruins.** Samaria, set high on a fortified hill, thought she was invincible. Yet Micah announces that her stones will be poured down into the valley and her

foundations laid bare – a word that came to fulfilment in **722 BC**, when the Assyrians took Samaria. Her wealth and her idols, gained through spiritual prostitution ("the wages of a prostitute" – *etnan* – אֶתְנַן), were carried off by plunderers to adorn their own pagan temples.

Living It Out

It is easy to read Micah 1 as an ancient history lesson about the fall of Samaria. But the Spirit of God aims that same cry – *"Hear!"* – straight at our hearts today.

We may no longer build stone images on the hills outside town, but every human heart is inclined to set up modern **"high places" (*bamot*)**. A high place is any place, system, relationship, career or financial security we run to for comfort, identity and safety instead of trusting the living God. Sometimes, just like Jerusalem in Micah's day, we even try to serve God and our idols at the same time: we keep the outward form of religion on Sundays, but during the week we bow at the altars of status, selfishness and material security.

Micah reminds us that God, in his loving jealousy for his children, will not let our false strongholds stand. When the Lord "comes down" into our lives and begins to shake or expose the false foundations we have relied on, he does it not to destroy us but to bring us back to the only Foundation that can never melt.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If the Lord looked today at the "capital city" of your thought life and your daily priorities, which "high places" (*bamot*) are competing with him for your deepest trust and loyalty?
- Are there areas of your life where you have quietly made peace with spiritual compromise because it looks advantageous or comfortable on the outside?

- How do you respond when God, through circumstances, "lays bare" a false security in your life right down to its foundations – with resistance, or with humility?
- In what way does your life today show the people around you that no one is like the LORD?

Prayer

> *Holy and almighty Lord, you live in the highest heaven, and yet you come down to see what is happening on the earth and in my heart. I bow before you in reverence today. Make me aware again of your greatness and your spotless holiness. Keep me from ever growing so used to your grace that I imagine you overlook my compromises and my divided loyalty.*
>
> *Lord, search the foundations of my life today. Where I have set up stubborn "high places" in my heart – where I have looked for my security in my own abilities, my possessions or the approval of people – break those idols down by your Spirit. Let my pride melt like wax before the fire of your presence.*
>
> *Build my life anew on the pure, unshakeable rock of your Word and your covenant love. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

DAY 2

Lament for the Lowlands: When Judgement Comes Close to Home

SCRIPTURE

Micah 1:8–16

8 Because of this I will lament and wail;
I will go stripped and naked;
I will make a lament like the jackals
and a mourning like the ostriches.
9 For her wounds are incurable;
it has come as far as Judah,
it has reached the gate of my people,
as far as Jerusalem.
10 In Gath do not tell it;
do not weep at all.
In Beth-leaphrah
roll yourself in the dust.
11 Pass on your way,
inhabitant of Shaphir, in nakedness and shame.
The inhabitant of Zaanan
has not come out.
The lament of Beth-ezel –
it will take from you its standing place.
12 For the inhabitant of Maroth
waits in anguish for good,
for evil has come down from the LORD
to the gate of Jerusalem.
13 Harness the chariot to the steed,
inhabitant of Lachish!
She was the beginning of sin for Daughter Zion,
for in you were found the rebellions of Israel.
14 Therefore you will give parting gifts
to Moresheth-gath;
the houses of Achzib will be a deceit
to the kings of Israel.
15 Once more I will bring the one who takes possession to you,
inhabitant of Mareshah;
as far as Adullam

the glory of Israel will come.
16 Make yourself bald and shave your head
for the children of your delight;
make your baldness as wide as the vulture's,
for they have gone from you into exile.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the first seven verses of chapter 1, Micah announced the fall of Samaria, the proud capital of the northern kingdom (Israel). Many people in the southern kingdom (Judah) found it easy to look at their northern neighbours with a sense of religious superiority and think: *"Samaria is getting what she deserves – but we are safe, because the temple of the* LORD *stands in Jerusalem."*

In verses 8 and 9 Micah pulls away that false blanket of complacency. Samaria's spiritual and political wounds (*makkoteha* – מַכּוֹתֶיהָ) are incurable (*anushah* – אֲנוּשָׁה), and like a deadly infection they have spread across the border into Judah, right up to the gate of Jerusalem. Historically, Micah is already seeing in the Spirit what would happen in **701 BC**, when the Assyrian king **Sennacherib** invaded Judah. Before Sennacherib besieged Jerusalem, his army swept like a devastating flood through the *Shephelah* – the fertile hill country where Micah himself lived. By his own inscriptions, he took forty-six of Judah's fortified cities and countless villages.

What makes this passage so moving is that Micah is no cool, detached observer. The towns he lists in verses 10 to 15 are his own neighbouring villages and his own birthplace. He knows the faces of the farmers, the mothers and the children whom this judgement is about to strike.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

In the original Hebrew, verses 10–15 are among the most brilliant pieces of poetry in the Old Testament – a lament full of wordplay. Micah plays sharply (*paronomasia*) on the names of **eleven towns in and around the Shephelah**, so that each town's name becomes a prophetic mirror of its own downfall:

- **Gath (*Gat* – גַּת – sounds like *taggidu* – תַּגִּידוּ, "tell"):** *"In Gath do not tell it."* Micah is quoting David's famous lament over Saul and Jonathan (2 Samuel 1:20). The Philistine neighbours must not even hear the sound of Judah's weeping and gloat over it.
- **Beth-leaphrah (*Bet le'afrah* – בֵּית לְעַפְרָה – "House of Dust"):** In "Dust-town" the people must literally roll in the dust (*'afar* – עָפָר) as a sign of the deepest grief and humiliation.
- **Shaphir (*Shafir* – שְׁפִיר – "beautiful", "lovely"):** The inhabitant of "Lovely-town" will lose her fine clothes and be led away in the shameful nakedness of prisoners of war.
- **Zaanan (*Tsa'anan* – צַאֲנָן – sounds like *yatsa'* – יָצָא, "go out"):** The people of "Go-out-town" sit trapped behind their walls in fear and do not even dare to go out to help their neighbours.
- **Beth-ezel (*Bet ha'etsel* – בֵּית הָאֵצֶל – "House of Nearness / Support"):** Their "Neighbour-house" lies in ruins itself and can offer no shelter, no standing place.
- **Maroth (*Marot* – מָרוֹת – related to *mar*, "bitter"):** The inhabitant of "Bitter-town" waits in anguish for good, but tastes only the bitterness of the disaster that reaches all the way to Jerusalem's gate.
- **Lachish (*Lakhish* – לָכִישׁ – sounds like *rekhesh* – רֶכֶשׁ, "steed"):** *"Harness the chariot to the steed, inhabitant of Lachish!"* Lachish was Judah's strongest fortress after Jerusalem and probably a base for chariots. The horses they trusted to win wars must now be hastily harnessed – to

flee! Micah adds: "*She was the beginning of sin for Daughter Zion*", because it was here that Judah learned, like the northern kingdom, to trust in military might, foreign alliances and idols instead of the LORD.

- **Moresheth-gath (*Moreshet Gat* – מוֹרֶשֶׁת גַּת – Micah's own home town; sounds like *me'orasah* – מְאֹרָשָׂה, "betrothed bride"):** Like a father who gives a dowry or parting gift (*shilluchim* – שִׁלּוּחִים) when his daughter leaves home, Judah must now say goodbye to Micah's beloved home town as it falls into the hands of a foreign conqueror.
- **Achzib (*Akhziv* – אַכְזִיב – sounds like *akhzav* – אַכְזָב, "a deceptive brook that dries up in the drought"):** In the scorching heat of the crisis, "Disappointment-town" will be to Judah's kings just like a dry riverbed – an empty promise with no water and no help.
- **Mareshah (*Mareshah* – מָרֵשָׁה – sounds like *hayoresh* – הַיֹּרֵשׁ, "the one who takes possession"):** Over "Heir-town" the LORD himself brings "the one who takes possession" – a foreign conqueror.
- **Adullam (*'Adullam* – עֲדֻלָּם):** Just as King David, centuries earlier, had to hide as a fugitive in the cave of Adullam (1 Samuel 22:1), so "the glory of Israel" – Judah's proud leaders and nobles – will now have to flee their palaces and hide in dark caves.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **True prophetic truth is always carried with tears.** Look at verse 8. Before Micah speaks a single word of judgement over his region, he takes off his clothes and goes stripped and naked (*sholal* – שׁוֹלָל, *'arom* – עָרוֹם – the appearance of a mourner and an exile), and he laments like the jackals and the ostriches. He never takes pleasure in the fall of sinners; his heart breaks with God's heart over "*my people*" (v. 9). This points ahead to Jesus Christ, who would weep over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41).

2. **Spiritual compromise respects no borders.** Judah thought it could admire and copy Samaria's prosperity and military habits without sharing Samaria's judgement. But sin is never an isolated matter. What was tolerated at the border fortress of Lachish finally pushed its way through to the gate of Jerusalem.
3. **False securities turn into our greatest disappointments.** Lachish's impressive chariots and Achzib's defensive walls could not save Judah once it had abandoned the LORD. Any earthly prop that takes God's place in our lives eventually becomes an *akhzav* – a dried-up brook just when our thirst is greatest.

Living It Out

Micah 1:8–16 confronts us on two deeply personal levels: **how we look at the sin and brokenness around us**, and **what we lean on in times of crisis.**

In our society it is very easy to slip into the role of the cynical critic. When we see moral decay in our country, corruption in leadership or spiritual lukewarmness in the church, our natural reaction is often outrage, gossip or an attitude of "*I told you so!*" But Micah shows us that you can only truly speak for God once you have learned to weep with God. True spiritual maturity does not stand at a safe distance throwing stones. It identifies with the need of "my people" and goes down on its knees in broken-hearted intercession.

Second, the story of **Lachish and Achzib** forces us to look at our own ramparts. Lachish was the place where Judah's eyes shifted away from the LORD to their own horses and chariots. For us today, "Lachish" can be the moment when our success, our bank balance, our health insurance or our own cleverness became more important to us than simple obedience to the Lord. It looks strong and impressive in times of peace, but on the day of real testing it turns out to be an "Achzib" – a spring that dries up precisely when you need water.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- When you look at the spiritual and moral brokenness in your community, your family or the church, what is your first reaction: critical condemnation from above, or a praying, compassionate heart like Micah's?
- What is the "Lachish" in your life – that good gift, ability or earthly security you have gradually begun to trust instead of the Lord alone?
- Have you ever experienced an earthly security letting you down like "Achzib" (a dry brook)? How did the Lord use that disappointment to call you back to himself, the living Spring?
- Is there a "small compromise" you allow on the outskirts of your life, thinking it will never reach the "gate of Jerusalem" (the heart of your relationship with God and your family)?

Prayer

Lord, my God and my Rock, as I look today into the mirror of Micah's words, I grow quiet before you. Forgive me for the times I have looked at other people's failings with a hard, critical heart, without weeping over them with your compassion. Give me the soft, broken heart of your Son, Jesus Christ – a heart that takes no pleasure in injustice or in people's fall, but stands in the gap in sincere love and intercession for my family, my community and my country.

Lord, I also confess how easily I, like Judah, trust in my own "horses and chariots". Keep me from building my hope on deceptive brooks that dry up in the time of drought. Wherever compromise has crept in at the borders of my heart, stop it today by your grace.

Be my only fortress, my shelter in the storm and my never-failing Spring. Amen.

DAY 3

Woe to Those Who Devise Wickedness on Their Beds! (Greed and Land-Grabbing)

SCRIPTURE

Micah 2:1–5

1 Woe to those who devise wickedness
and work evil on their beds!
In the light of morning they carry it out,
because it is in the power of their hand.
2 They covet fields and seize them,
and houses, and take them away;
they oppress a man and his house,
a person and his inheritance.
3 Therefore thus says the LORD:
Look, against this family I am devising evil,
from which you cannot remove your necks;
and you will not walk with heads held high,
for it will be a time of evil.
4 On that day they will take up a taunt-song against you
and wail a bitter lament:
"It is done!" one says.
"We are utterly ruined!
He exchanges the portion of my people.
How he takes it away from me!
To the renegade he divides up our fields."
5 Therefore you will have no one
to cast the measuring line by lot
in the assembly of the LORD.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In chapter 1 Micah turned the spotlight on the people's **vertical relationship with God**: their idolatry and their false spiritual securities. Here in chapter 2 he immediately shifts the focus to their **horizontal relationship with their neighbours**. In the biblical worldview the two are inseparable: when a society's reverence for God crumbles, its humanity and justice rot from the inside.

To grasp how serious Micah's charge in verses 1 to 5 is, we need to understand how land ownership worked in ancient Israel. According to the law of Moses (see Leviticus 25:23), the land belonged to the LORD himself. Every Israelite family had received an ancestral plot of land – an **inheritance** – as an inalienable covenant gift from God. That piece of ground was not simply "property" or a commodity. It guaranteed a family's freedom, its daily bread and its place in the covenant community (remember how Naboth, in 1 Kings 21:3, refused to sell his ancestral vineyard to King Ahab).

During the eighth century BC, however, a powerful, wealthy elite in Jerusalem and Samaria began to build up large estates. When smallholders in the countryside (like Micah's own neighbours in the Shephelah) fell into debt through drought or heavy taxes, these rich landowners abused their financial power and bribed courts to seize the smallholders' family land. Free citizens of the covenant were stripped of their inheritance and reduced to impoverished day labourers or slaves.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Woe (*hoy* – הוֹי):** Micah opens verse 1 with the Hebrew cry *Hoy!* Originally this was the wail raised at a funeral. When a prophet cries *hoy* over living, successful people, he is in effect saying: "*You think you are flourishing, but spiritually speaking you are already on the way to your own funeral.*"

- **From coveting (*chamad* – חָמַד) to seizing (*gazal* – גָּזַל):** In verse 2 Micah lays bare the exact anatomy of sin: "*They covet fields and seize them.*" The verb *chamad* is the same word used in the Tenth Commandment ("*Do not covet the house of your neighbour*" – Exodus 20:17). What begins as a quiet, untamed desire in the heart on the bed ends at daybreak in *gazal* – a word that means to tear something away by force, to hijack it.
- **"Because it is in the power of their hand" (*yesh le'el yadam* – יֶשׁ לְאֵל יָדָם):** In this fascinating Hebrew idiom in verse 1, the word for "power" (*el*) is the same as the word for "God". So one can also hear it as: "*because their hand is a god to them.*" It describes the arrogant attitude of "might makes right": if I have the financial leverage, the clever contracts or the position to overpower someone, then I have the right to do it.
- **Divine wordplay and poetic justice (*chashav* – חָשַׁב):** Notice the sharp reversal between verse 1 and verse 3. In verse 1 the oppressors lie on their beds and **devise** (*chashav* – plan, weave) wickedness against the defenceless. In verse 3 the LORD answers: "*Look, against this family I am devising evil*"! The crafty schemers run headlong into the sovereign Planner of the universe.
- **Inheritance (*nachalah* – נַחֲלָה):** In verse 2 Micah stresses that they oppress "*a man and his house, a person and his inheritance.*" To steal someone's *nachalah* was to wipe out his future, his family's security and his God-given place in Israel.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Sin is hatched in the mind before it is carried out in daylight.** The bed is meant to be a place of rest, prayer and surrender to God (see Psalm 4:4; 63:6 – Hebrew 4:5; 63:7). But when a heart is ruled by greed, the night hours become a workshop where selfish plans are forged.
2. **Legal in human eyes does not mean righteous in God's eyes.** The land-grabbers of Judah probably did not turn up with swords. They used promissory notes, interest rates and corrupt judges. It was within

"the power of their hand". But God looks past our technical excuses and sees the exploitation of a fellow human being.

3. **Material greed is always an attack on people.** For the greedy it is only about "fields and houses" (things). But in verse 2 the LORD shows that behind every field and house stands *"a man and his house"*. When we put profit or self-interest above people, we violate those who bear God's image.
4. **God's judgement fits the offence perfectly.** Those who strutted about with proud necks and took other people's land will soon wear a heavy yoke of foreign rule on their necks and will no longer walk with heads held high (v. 3). The Assyrian and Babylonian conquerors would eventually divide up the rich landowners' own estates, so that they would stand empty-handed in the assembly of the LORD – with no one to cast the measuring line for them (vv. 4–5).

Living It Out

We may not live in an ancient agricultural economy where we literally annex our neighbour's wheat field, but the spirit of Micah 2:1–5 is alive and well in our modern world – and often very subtly in our own hearts.

The first mirror this text holds up to us is **what we do with our thoughts when no one is watching**. Where do your thoughts wander when you lie awake at night or in the quiet moments of the day? Do we plan how to get back at someone who has wronged us? Do we compare ourselves with others and nurse envy (*chamad*) of their success, their house, their position or their life? James 1:14–15 reminds us that when desire has conceived, it gives birth to sin. If we do not submit our thoughts to Christ on our "beds", they will spill over into our words and deeds tomorrow morning.

The second mirror is **how we use the "power of our hand"**. Each of us has power, influence or leverage in some area – as an employer, a manager, a businessperson, a parent, a spouse or a consumer. The world's rule is: *If*

you have the upper hand, push your advantage as far as you can for your own gain. But a child of God asks a completely different question: not "What can I get out of this because I have the power?" but "How can I use my power to act justly and protect the other person's dignity?"

True wealth never lies in what we scrape together at other people's expense, but in contentment with the inheritance the Lord himself has measured out for us with the measuring line of his grace (Psalm 16:5–6).

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What do your thoughts usually turn over in the quiet hours of the night or early morning: are they dominated by worry, resentment and selfish ambition, or by trust and meditation on God's Word?
- Is there something in someone else's life right now (their possessions, recognition, gifts or circumstances) that you quietly covet (*chamad*), so that it robs you of gratitude for your own life?
- Think of the areas where you have authority or "leverage" over other people (at work, in financial dealings or at home). Do you ever use "the power of your hand" to get your own way at the expense of someone weaker?
- What does it look like in practice, in your daily work and decisions, to value people's worth and wellbeing above mere profit or personal advantage?

Prayer

> *Righteous and all-knowing Father, you see not only my deeds in daylight but also every thought I nurse in the dark on my bed. I come and bow before you honestly today. Cleanse the secret rooms of my heart and my imagination. Wherever envy, discontent or selfish calculation has taken root in my thoughts, please pull it out by your Spirit before it bears fruit in my actions.*

Lord, keep me from the pride that thinks that just because something is within the power of my hand, I have the right to grab it. Teach me to manage every bit of influence, authority and resources you have entrusted to me with integrity, gentleness and justice.

Make me content and deeply grateful for the precious inheritance I have already received in Christ – an inheritance that can never fade or be taken away. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 4

False Prophets and the Shepherd King Who Breaks Through (Ha-Porets)

SCRIPTURE

Micah 2:6–13

6 "Do not preach!" – so they preach.
"One should not preach about such things;
disgrace will not overtake us."
7 Should this be said, house of Jacob:
"Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient?
Are these his deeds?"
Do my words not do good
to the one who walks uprightly?
8 But lately my people has risen up as an enemy.
From off the garment you strip the cloak
from those who pass by in trust,
like men coming home from war.
9 The women of my people you drive out,
each from the house she delights in;
from her little children you take away
my splendour for ever.
10 Get up and go!
For this is not the resting place;
because of uncleanness it brings destruction,
a grievous destruction.
11 If a man came walking in wind and falsehood
and lied: "I will preach to you about wine and strong drink!" –
he would be the preacher for this people.
12 I will surely gather all of you, Jacob;
I will surely assemble the remnant of Israel.
I will put them together like sheep in a fold,
like a flock in the midst of its pasture;
they will be noisy with people.
13 The one who breaks open goes up before them;
they break through, pass through the gate
and go out by it.
Their king passes on before them,

and the LORD at their head.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Having exposed Judah's greedy landowners in verses 1 to 5, Micah describes in verses 6 to 13 his dramatic clash with the religious elite of his day. Nobody likes having their secret sins and dishonest gain addressed in public. Instead of repenting, the leaders and their hired hands – the false prophets – try to silence Micah: *"One should not preach about such things"* (v. 6).

They hide behind a twisted covenant theology. Because they are the "house of Jacob" and have the temple in their midst, they believe they are immune to God's judgement (*"disgrace will not overtake us"*). While they boast of God's grace with their lips, in their daily dealings they behave like an enemy army against their own defenceless fellow countrymen: they strip the cloak off peaceful passers-by who walk past without suspicion, and they put widows and their children out on the street (vv. 8–9).

And then, just when the judgement in verses 10 and 11 looks at its darkest, something wonderful happens in verses 12 and 13. Like a bright ray of sunlight suddenly breaking through heavy storm clouds, Micah gives the **first great messianic promise of salvation** in his book. God's covenant faithfulness is greater than the unfaithfulness of Judah's leaders. He himself will assemble the scattered remnant like a shepherd and go out before them as *Ha-Porets* – "the one who breaks open", the Breaker.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **To "drip" (*nataf* – נָטַף):** In verses 6 and 11 the Hebrew text does not use the usual word for prophesying (*nava'*), but the verb *nataf*, which literally means "**to drip**" – words that drip down like rain (we translate it "preach"). Used disparagingly, it means something like "**to drivel, to go**

on and on". Micah's opponents mock him: "Do not preach!" – so they preach – as if to say, *"Stop dripping your gloomy words on us!"* In verse 11 Micah turns the same word back on them with biting irony: if a liar turned up saying, *"I will preach to you about wine and strong drink!"* (symbols of carefree prosperity and partying), they would instantly make him their favourite preacher – *"he would be the preacher for this people."*

- **Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient? (*qatsar* – קָצַר):** In verse 7 Micah quotes their pious excuse: *"Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient?"* Literally they ask whether the Spirit of the LORD is "short" – in Hebrew a "short spirit" means being impatient or powerless. The leaders reason that God is surely patient and gracious and would never bring such severe judgements on his people. The LORD answers them bluntly: his words do indeed do good (*yetivu* – יֵיטִיבוּ, from *yatav*), but specifically *"to the one who walks uprightly"* (*yashar* – יָשָׁר) – not to those who hide behind religious slogans while exploiting their neighbour.
- **The resting place (*menuchah* – מְנוּחָה) and uncleanness (*tum'ah* – טָמְאָה):** The promised land was meant to be Israel's *menuchah* – a place of peace, security and rest in God's presence (see Deuteronomy 12:9; Psalm 95:11). But through their cruelty to women and children they have defiled the land morally. That is why God cries out in verse 10: *"Get up and go! For this is not the resting place"*. Their exploitation leads straight into exile.
- **The Breaker (*haporets* – הַפֹּרֵץ):** In verses 12–13 the imagery changes to a great sheepfold (*botsrah* – בָּצְרָה – which can mean an enclosed fold or the city of Bozrah). At first the flock is trapped behind the walls of siege and exile. But then comes **the Breaker** (*haporets*, from the verb *parats*, "to break a gap in a wall"). The King breaks open the prison gate, walks out ahead of his flock and leads them into freedom.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The human heart often prefers soothing lies to healing truth.** When we cling to our sins, we experience God's warnings as "negative" and "judgemental". Then we look for spiritual voices that soothe our conscience and bless our selfish lifestyle (see 2 Timothy 4:3–4).
2. **How you respond to God's Word reveals the state of your walk.** For the person who wants to walk uprightly with God, even Scripture's sharpest rebuke is beneficial and life-giving (v. 7). It is only when we live in rebellion against God that his Word feels like an enemy.
3. **Exploiting the defenceless robs the next generation of God's splendour.** Look at the moving words of verse 9: "*from her little children you take away my splendour for ever*" (*hadari* – הֲדָרִי – my glory, my dignity). When families are destroyed by greed and injustice, children are robbed of the spiritual and material heritage with which God wanted to crown them.
4. **Christ is our ultimate Breaker (*Haporets*).** This prophecy saw a provisional fulfilment when God rescued the Jewish remnant during Sennacherib's siege in 701 BC, and later when he brought them back from exile in Babylon. But its complete fulfilment lies in **Jesus Christ, the Good Shepherd** (John 10:1–16). He came into the fold of our lost humanity, broke through the insurmountable wall of sin, death and the grave, and now goes ahead of his church as King to the eternal resting place.

Living It Out

Micah 2:6–13 makes us ask honestly **which voices we listen to** and **how we respond to the sharp edges of God's Word**.

We live at a time when it is easier than ever to build ourselves a spiritual "echo chamber". We can read books, listen to sermons and follow people who tell us only what we want to hear – messages of "wine and strong drink" that promise earthly success, self-fulfilment and comfort without

ever mentioning cross-bearing, repentance or self-denial. Then, when the Holy Spirit, through Scripture or a fellow believer, puts his finger on a specific sin – our temper, our unforgiveness, our love of money or our hypocrisy – our natural reflex is to say, like Judah's leaders: *"Don't talk about such things! God is love!"* But true spiritual health begins on the day we welcome the surgeon's knife of God's Word, because we know his words do good to everyone who wants to walk uprightly.

At the same time, verses 12 and 13 bring us inexpressible comfort. Perhaps today you feel trapped behind thick walls – walls of old mistakes, spiritual discouragement, broken relationships or circumstances from which you see no way out. Remember who your King is. His name is **the Breaker (*Haporets*)**. He does not send you ahead alone to hack out a path. He breaks open the gate himself, he walks right at the front, and all you need to do is follow in his footsteps.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- How do you react inwardly when a passage of Scripture or a message challenges an area of your life you are attached to: do you defend yourself and silence the voice, or do you bow before the truth?
- Which "false preachers of wine and strong drink" (in our culture, the media or even within church circles) are currently tempting you to see earthly comfort and prosperity as the highest goal of your faith?
- In what practical way can you stand up today for the "women and children" or the vulnerable people around you, so that God's splendour (*hadari*) in their lives is protected?
- What wall of impossibility or fear are you staring at right now, where you need to look up to Jesus as *Haporets* – the King who breaks open the way before you?

Prayer

Lord, my Shepherd and my King, thank you for the pure, unadulterated truth of your Word. Keep my heart from ever growing hard or deaf to your voice when you correct me. Forgive me for the times I preferred to listen to soothing half-truths rather than let my life be examined in the light of your holiness. Make me someone who walks uprightly before you, so that even your sternest words will be sweet and wholesome to me.

Give me a soft, protective heart for the defenceless, for children and for those who have no defence against the harshness of this world.

And today, Lord Jesus, I praise you as my Breaker! Where I feel trapped in fear, worry or human inability, I thank you that you have already broken through the gates of death and the grave. Go ahead of me today as my King; I follow you with complete trust. Amen.

DAY 5

Leaders Who Twist Justice and Prophets Who Prophesy for Money

SCRIPTURE

Micah 3:1–7

[1] And I said:
Hear, please, you heads of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel!
Is it not for you to know justice?
[2] You who hate good and love evil,
who tear their skin from off them
and their flesh from off their bones;
[3] who eat the flesh of my people
and strip their skin from off them,
break their bones in pieces
and chop them up like meat for the pot,
like flesh in the cauldron.
[4] Then they will cry out to the LORD,
but he will not answer them;
he will hide his face from them at that time,
because they have made their deeds evil.
[5] Thus says the LORD concerning the prophets
who lead my people astray,
who, when they have something to bite with their teeth,
call out "Peace!",
but whoever puts nothing into their mouths,
against him they sanctify war:
[6] Therefore it will be night for you, without vision,
and darkness for you, without divination.
The sun will go down on the prophets,
and the day will grow dark over them.
[7] The seers will be ashamed
and the diviners disgraced;
they will all cover their lips,
for there is no answer from God.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With the words "*Hear, please*" (*shim'u na* – שִׁמְעוּ נָא) Micah 3 begins a new series of oracles. In chapter 1 Micah addressed the nation as a whole; in chapter 2 he confronted the wealthy land barons who pulled the strings behind the scenes. Now the prophet walks straight into the highest seats of power in Jerusalem and addresses the two pillars that were meant to carry society: **the civil leaders and judges** (vv. 1–4) and **the religious prophets** (vv. 5–7).

In ancient Israel the court at the city gate was the last refuge of the widow, the orphan and the impoverished smallholder. The heads and rulers had been appointed by God to be shepherds of the people. But in Micah's day the shepherds had become butchers. Worse still: while the political leaders were draining the people financially and physically, the official prophets – who were supposed to be the nation's conscience – hired out their voices to the highest bidder. As long as they were well paid, they pronounced religious blessing over a thoroughly corrupt system.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **To "know" justice (*lada'at et hammishpat* – לָדַעַת אֶת הַמִּשְׁפָּט):** In verse 1 Micah asks: "*Is it not for you to know justice (mishpat)?*" In Hebrew the verb *yada'* (know) means far more than intellectual knowledge of legal clauses. It speaks of an **intimate, lived relationship and practical commitment**. The leaders could probably recite the laws of Moses by heart, but because they hated good and loved evil (v. 2), they had completely rejected the heart of God's justice.
- **The shocking butcher metaphor (vv. 2–3):** Micah does not shy away from raw, shocking imagery. To expose the leaders' economic exploitation, he describes them as cannibals and butchers. First they tear and strip off the skin (*gazal* – גָּזַל, v. 2; *pashat* – פָּשַׁט, v. 3), then they tear the

flesh from the bones, break the bones (*patsach* – פָּצַח) as if to suck out the last bit of marrow, and chop the pieces up for the pot and the cauldron (*sir* – סִיר and *qallachat* – קַלַּחַת). Why does the Spirit of God use such gruesome language? Because corrupt leaders like to hide their deeds behind tidy bookkeeping, tax laws and court orders. God rips away the veil and shows what injustice looks like in heaven's eyes: it literally devours people's lives and dignity.

- **Prophets who "bite with their teeth" (*hannoshekhim* – הַנֹּשְׁכִים, from *nashakh* – נָשַׁךְ):** In verse 5 the LORD says that the false prophets call out "Peace!" (*shalom*) "*when they have something to bite with their teeth*". Elsewhere in the Old Testament the verb *nashakh* is used for **the venomous bite of a snake** (Numbers 21:6), and from the same root comes *neshekh* – **usury**, cruel interest that bites a person to death financially. These prophets are spiritual mercenaries. If a rich man fills their hands with silver or food, they guarantee him God's favour (*shalom*). But whoever puts nothing into their mouths, "*against him they sanctify war*" (*weqiddeshu 'alaw milchamah* – וְקִדְּשׁוּ עָלָיו מִלְחָמָה) – they abuse holy, religious language to destroy that person's name and to present him as accursed!
- **Covering the lips (*we'atu 'al safam* – וְעָטוּ עַל שָׂפָם):** In verse 7 the shamed seers must cover their upper lip or moustache (*safam*). According to Leviticus 13:45 this was the prescribed gesture of a leper (who had to cry out, "Unclean! Unclean!"), and according to Ezekiel 24:17 and 22 a sign of deep mourning. Those who claimed to be God's mouthpiece must now cover their own mouths in shame.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Leadership and influence are a sacred stewardship, never a privilege for self-service.** Whether in the state, in business, in the church or in the family – God gives authority so that the strong can protect the

weak and help them flourish. When leaders use their position to put meat in their own pot at the expense of those in their care, they betray God, who speaks of *"my people"* (v. 3).

2. **How we treat people determines whether God listens to our prayers.** Verse 4 contains one of the most serious warnings in all of Scripture: *"Then they will cry out to the* LORD*, but he will not answer them; he will hide his face from them at that time."* God does not let himself be manipulated by pious prayers while our hands are busy harming our neighbour (see Proverbs 21:13; Isaiah 1:15; 1 Peter 3:7).
3. **When spiritual truth is traded for human favour, the light goes out.** The false prophets squandered their calling for comfort and approval. The just penalty is spiritual blindness – a *"night … without vision"* in which the sun goes down on their discernment (v. 6). If you refuse to speak God's truth when it costs you something, you eventually lose the ability to hear his voice when you need it most.

Living It Out

It is easy to read Micah 3 and immediately think of corrupt politicians or greedy television preachers in our own day. But the word of God is a two-edged sword that always aims at our own heart first before it points outward.

First, verses 1 to 4 ask each of us: **How am I using the authority and influence entrusted to me?** You don't have to be a president or a judge to be a "head" or "ruler" in your own small world. Perhaps you manage a team at work, have employees, lead a ministry, or are the head of a household. Do you use the people around you as "ingredients" for your own comfort, your own standing and your own emotional "cooking pot"? Or do you use your strength to build up their dignity and lighten their loads? And if your prayer life feels dry right now and the heavens seem made of bronze, ask the Holy Spirit to search your relationships: is there someone towards whom you have acted harshly, unjustly or exploitatively?

Second, verses 5 to 7 prick our own tendency towards "**transactional love and truth**". See how subtly human nature works: we are often very friendly, generous with compliments and full of *shalom* towards people who can put something into our mouths – people who can advance our career, raise our social standing or flatter our ego. But how do we treat the person who can give us absolutely nothing back, or the one who challenges our selfishness? Do we then quietly declare "war" on them in our attitude – through coldness, gossip or exclusion? True children of God speak the truth and show love without a price tag attached.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do you know God's justice (*mishpat*) only as a theological concept in your head, or does it become visible in the way you speak to and deal with the people under your authority or in service roles every day?
- Is there any injustice, bitterness or exploitation in your relationships that is standing like a wall between you and God's face in your prayer life right now (v. 4)?
- Be honest about your motives in relationships: do you treat people who can give you advantage, recognition or popularity (who put something into your mouth) better than those who have nothing to offer you?
- Have you ever kept silent about an important spiritual or moral truth because you were afraid it would cost you financial advantage, friendship or people's approval?

Prayer

> *Holy and righteous Lord, Protector of the weak and Judge of all the earth, today I bow in deep awe before your word. Forgive me for the times I have known your truth with my mind but have been selfish and harsh towards others in my daily conduct. Keep me from ever using people to serve my own ambition or comfort while forgetting that every person I touch is precious in your eyes.*

Lord, search my relationships today. Wherever there is injustice, loveless-ness or neglect in my life that causes you to hide your face from my prayers, show it to me, so that I can put it right before you and before my neighbour.

Deliver me from a mercenary heart that hands out peace and kindness only when I can get something out of it. Never let the sun of your Spirit and your word go down over my heart, but make me a pure, selfless channel of your grace and truth. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 6

Filled with the Spirit of the LORD: True Courage and Judgement on Zion

SCRIPTURE

Micah 3:8–12

8 But as for me, I am filled with power,
with the Spirit of the LORD,
with justice and with might,
to declare to Jacob his rebellion
and to Israel his sin.
9 Hear this, please, you heads of the house of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel,
who abhor justice
and twist everything that is straight,
10 who build Zion with blood
and Jerusalem with injustice!
11 Her heads judge for a bribe,
her priests teach for a price,
and her prophets divine for money;
yet they lean on the LORD and say:
"Is not the LORD in our midst?
No evil will come upon us."
12 Therefore, because of you,
Zion will be ploughed as a field,
Jerusalem will become heaps of ruins,
and the mountain of the house a wooded height.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With Micah 3:8–12 the first great movement of the book of Micah (chapters 1–3) reaches its dramatic climax. In the preceding verses we saw how the official prophets of Jerusalem were plunged into spiritual darkness and had to cover their mouths in shame because they had sold the truth for money. Over against this corrupt majority Micah now steps forward with one of the most powerful personal confessions in the whole Old Testament: "***But as for me, I am filled with power, with the Spirit of the*** LORD***, with justice and with might ...***" (v. 8).

Historically, Jerusalem in the late eighth century BC was a city full of impressive building projects. After the fall of the Northern Kingdom (722 BC) many refugees probably streamed into Jerusalem, and the city grew rapidly. To fund new defensive walls, water tunnels (see 2 Kings 20:20) and luxurious palaces for the nobility, the leaders laid heavy burdens on the poor rural population. When an ordinary citizen looked at Jerusalem, he saw gleaming limestone walls and a beautiful temple; but when God looked at Jerusalem, he saw a city built "*with blood*" and "*with injustice*" (v. 10).

The shock of Micah's closing words in verse 12 can hardly be overstated. For the people of Judah it was unthinkable that God would ever allow his own dwelling place – Mount Zion and Solomon's temple – to be destroyed. And yet we know from **Jeremiah 26:17–19** (more than a hundred years later) that Micah's brave preaching was not in vain. When King Hezekiah heard this sharp word of judgement from the mouth of the country prophet from Moresheth, he humbled himself before the LORD, so that God averted the destruction of Jerusalem in Hezekiah's days (until the city was finally destroyed by Babylon in 586 BC).

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **"But as for me ..." (*we'ulam anokhi* – וְאוּלָם אָנֹכִי):** The Hebrew construction at the start of verse 8 sets up a deliberate, sharp contrast. On one side stand the professional prophets who sell their voices; on the other stands *anokhi* ("I myself"). Micah does not appeal to a royal appointment, academic standing or family connections, but solely to the *ruach* YHWH (רוּחַ יְהוָה) – the Spirit of the LORD.
- **The threefold equipping of the Spirit (*koach*, *mishpat*, *gevurah*):** Micah names three specific gifts with which the Spirit has filled him:
- ***Koach*** (כֹּחַ – power): the spiritual and physical stamina to stay standing when everyone around you gives way.
- ***Mishpat*** (מִשְׁפָּט – justice): the ability to see right and wrong through God's eyes, untainted by bribes or fear of people.
- ***Gevurah*** (גְּבוּרָה – might): the word is related to *gibbor* (גִּבּוֹר), a hero or warrior. It is the courage to speak unpopular truths straight into the faces of powerful people.
- **To "twist" everything that is straight (*ye'aqqeshu* – יְעַקְּשׁוּ, from *'aqash*):** In verse 9 Micah accuses the leaders of being those who *"twist everything that is straight"*: what is straight (*yashar*) they bend crooked and warped (*'aqash*). Instead of the court being a straight measure of fairness, they bend the rules so that they always favour the rich.
- **False "leaning" on the LORD (*yisha'enu* – יִשָּׁעֲנוּ, from *sha'an* – שָׁעַן):** In verse 11 all three pillars of Judah's society appear side by side: the **heads** (politics and the courts), the **priests** (teaching the law) and the **prophets** (revelation). All three groups are driven by one thing: **money**. And yet *"they lean on the* LORD*"*. The verb *sha'an* means to lean your full weight on a staff or a wall. They use God's covenant promises as a religious crutch to soothe their conscience while living in open disobedience.

- **Coming full circle – from high places to wooded heights (*bamot ya'ar* – בָּמוֹת יְעַר):** In Micah 1:5 the prophet asked: *"And what are the high places (bamot) of Judah? Is it not Jerusalem?"* Here at the end of chapter 3 (v. 12) he uses the word *bamot* again. Because Jerusalem itself has become a spiritual *bamah* (pagan high place), the temple mount will literally become *bamot ya'ar* – a wooded height, deserted hills overgrown with scrub. Lamentations 5:18 later describes exactly such a scene: foxes prowling over desolate Mount Zion.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **True spiritual authority comes from the Holy Spirit, not from human approval.** Micah had no earthly power structure behind him. But because he was filled with the Spirit of the LORD, his words brought a king to repentance and have lived on in Scripture for centuries, while his popular opponents have vanished into oblivion.
2. **When money becomes the driving force of service and worship, a community's soul rots.** Verse 11 shows how every noble calling – to judge rightly, to teach God's word and to proclaim his will – is profaned as soon as the question is no longer what is right before God, but what it pays me.
3. **Religious symbols can never protect us from God's judgement if our hearts are far from him.** Judah's leaders thought the mere presence of the temple in Jerusalem made them untouchable (*"Is not the LORD in our midst?"*). But God cares more about an obedient heart than about holy buildings (see Jeremiah 7:4; Matthew 3:9).
4. **God's sharpest word of judgement is always a gracious call to repentance.** Why does the LORD announce that Zion will be ploughed as a field? Not because he delights in destruction, but to break open the hard ground of human pride so that there is room for true repentance – exactly the way King Hezekiah responded to this very message.

Living It Out

At the end of these first three chapters of Micah we face a choice between two ways of life: the way of **verse 8** (Micah's Spirit-filled integrity) and the way of **verse 11** (the leaders' calculating hypocrisy).

Every one of us faces moments today when it is easier, safer and more profitable to swim with the current. At work, in business or in our social circles we are often expected to bend a little of what is straight (*'aqash*) – to tell a seemingly harmless lie, to keep quiet when someone is treated unfairly, or to leave our Christian principles at the door so that we can get ahead. In our own strength we are all prone to the fear of people. But the same Spirit who filled Micah with **power (*koach*), justice (*mishpat*) and might (*gevurah*)** lives today in every believer in Christ (see 2 Timothy 1:7: "For God did not give us a spirit of cowardice, but of power and of love and of self-control").

Second, verse 11 warns us against the danger of **cheap grace and mere formal religion**. It is possible to sit in church every Sunday, quote Christian slogans (the Lord is with us, after all!) and "lean" on outward religious habits, while never asking in our business practices, our finances and our relationships what really pleases the Lord. God does not ask us for a shiny outward façade built at the expense of others; he asks for a life in which our Sunday confession and our Monday integrity are one and the same thing.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- In which specific situation in your life today do you need the Holy Spirit's threefold equipping of **power**, **justice** and **might** (v. 8) to stand up for the truth or to make a difficult but just decision?
- What are you "building" your career, your finances or your family life with at the moment (v. 10)? Are you building with integrity and a spirit of service, or sometimes at the cost of other people's rest and wellbeing?

- Examine your heart in the light of verse 11: do you ever use God's grace and his promises of protection as an excuse to carry on with a habit or attitude you know he disapproves of?
- When King Hezekiah heard Micah 3:12, he humbled himself and changed his ways. What one concrete change is the Lord calling you to make as a result of our journey through Micah 1 to 3?

Prayer

> *Almighty Father and Lord of hosts, at the end of these deep and searching chapters I bow before you in humility. I confess that so often, out of fear of people or love of my own comfort, I keep silent when I should speak, or give in when I should stand firm.*
>
> *Fill me again today with your Holy Spirit – give me your power to persevere, your clear insight to tell right from wrong, and your courage to live for your truth with gentleness but without compromise.*
>
> *Lord, keep me from the self-deception of mere formal religion. Never let me lean on my own religious habits while my heart is far from you. Through your word, plough up today any hard, proud or selfish ground in my heart, so that my life will not be a heap of ruins of self-will but a living temple where your Spirit truly reigns. In the name of Jesus Christ, our true King and Redeemer, Amen.*

DAY 7

From Ruins to Paradise: When Swords Become Ploughshares

SCRIPTURE

Micah 4:1–5

1 And it will come to pass in the last days
that the mountain of the house of the LORD
will stand firm as the highest of the mountains
and be lifted up above the hills,
and peoples will stream to it.
2 Many nations will come and say:
"Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD,
to the house of the God of Jacob,
so that he may teach us his ways
and we may walk in his paths."
For from Zion instruction will go out,
and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.
3 He will judge between many peoples
and settle disputes for mighty nations far away.
They will beat their swords into ploughshares
and their spears into pruning knives.
Nation will not lift up sword against nation,
and they will no longer learn war.
4 They will sit, each under his vine
and under his fig tree,
and no one will make them afraid;
for the mouth of the LORD of hosts has spoken.
5 For all the peoples walk,
each in the name of its god,
but we will walk in the name of the LORD our God
for ever and ever.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

There are few contrasts in the whole Bible as breathtaking as the move from the last verse of Micah 3 to the first verse of Micah 4. At the end of chapter 3 (v. 12) we looked at a smouldering heap of ruins: because of the corruption of Judah's leaders, Zion would be ploughed as a field and the temple mount would become a deserted hill overgrown with scrub (*bamot ya'ar*). If the book of Micah had ended there, we would have been left in utter despair.

But God's judgement is never his last word for his covenant people. With the words "*And it will come to pass in the last days ...*" the Spirit of God pulls back the curtain of history and shows us that human sin can never wreck God's eternal plan of salvation. This same prophecy appears almost word for word in Micah's contemporary, **Isaiah 2:2–4**. While the mighty Assyrian empire was trampling nations with iron weapons and subduing peoples through fear, Micah sees a completely different kingdom on the horizon – a kingdom that does not spread through military force but through the attraction of God's truth and righteousness.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **In the last days (*be'acharit hayyamim* – בְּאַחֲרִית הַיָּמִים):** Literally "at the end of the days". In prophetic literature this phrase refers to the messianic age – the future towards which all history is moving, when God establishes his kingdom in fullness. In the New Testament we see that these "last days" have already dawned with the first coming, death and resurrection of Jesus Christ (see Acts 2:17; Hebrews 1:2) and will be brought to perfect completion at his return.
- **Peoples who "stream uphill" (*wenaharu* – וְנָהֲרוּ, from *nahar*):** Verse 1 says that "*peoples will stream to it*". The Hebrew verb *nahar* means to flow like a mighty river (*nahar*). In nature, water always flows downhill, from the mountains to the lowlands. But here a supernatural won-

der takes place: the nations of the world flow like a river **uphill**, up the mountain of the LORD! It shows that the pull of God's grace is stronger than the natural gravity of human selfishness and division.

- **Instruction (*torah* – תּוֹרָה) from Zion:** When verse 2 says "For *from* Zion *instruction will go out*", *torah* at root does not mean a cold list of prohibitions but **loving, fatherly instruction and direction** (from the root *yarah*, to point the way). The nations do not come because they are forced to, but because they long to learn how to live according to the Creator's design ("*so that he may teach us his ways*").
- **From swords to ploughshares and pruning knives (*charvotehem* – חַרְבֹתֵיהֶם to *'ittim* – אִתִּים):** In verse 3 the nations beat their swords (*charavot*, from *cherev*) into ploughshares or mattocks (*'ittim*) and their spears (*chanitot*) into pruning knives (*mazmerot*). The same metal that was once used to destroy human lives is transformed by the fire of God's judgement into farming tools that bring forth food, life and blessing.
- **Under the vine and the fig tree (v. 4):** In ancient Israelite culture this was the highest picture of *shalom* (peace and prosperity; see 1 Kings 4:25, Hebrew 5:5; Zechariah 3:10). Vines and fig trees need years of stable peace to grow and bear fruit; in war they were the first things enemy armies cut down. In Micah 2:1–2 the rich land-grabbers robbed the smallholders of their fields and houses, but in God's renewed kingdom even the humblest citizen sits in complete safety (*we'ein macharid* – וְאֵין מַחֲרִיד: "*and no one will make them afraid*").

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's grace re-creates what human sin has destroyed.** The very mountain that at the end of chapter 3 became a deserted wooded hill because of corrupt leadership is lifted up by God himself at the beginning of chapter 4 as the spiritual centre of the world. Where people tear down, God builds anew.

2. **True peace (*shalom*) is the fruit of God's word and judgement, not of human diplomacy alone.** Notice the order in verses 2 and 3. The nations lay down their weapons only *after* the word of the LORD has gone out from Jerusalem and he has judged (*shafat*) between them and settled their disputes (*hokhiach*, from *yakach* – to correct, set right). There can be no outward peace between people without inward submission to the King's truth.
3. **The gospel is meant for all nations.** Centuries in advance, Micah already sees that God's salvation would not stay limited to ethnic Israel. "Many nations" and "mighty nations far away" call one another to come to the God of Jacob – a prophecy that is fulfilled today every time people from every language and culture kneel before Jesus Christ.
4. **Future hope demands faithful walking today.** Verse 5 is the practical anchor of this vision. We do not wait passively for the consummation. While the world around us still runs after its own idols of power, money and self-promotion, the believer makes a clear choice today: *"but we will walk in the name of the LORD our God for ever and ever."*

Living It Out

We live in a world that groans daily under the clatter of "swords and spears" – not only the physical wars and violence we see on the news, but also the sharp words, bitterness, family conflict and cold warfare in our workplaces and homes. It is so easy to lose heart when we see injustice apparently winning and spiritual values being reduced to rubble.

Micah 4:1–5 gives us as believers a **compass of firm hope**. It reminds us that history is not drifting aimlessly or heading for a cosmic accident; it is moving unstoppably towards the day when the reign of Jesus Christ over the whole earth will be visible.

But this text also calls us **to be citizens of that coming kingdom already today**. You don't have to wait for the second coming to bring your personal "swords and spears" into the forge of God's grace. Every time you

refuse to answer a sharp, hurtful remark with an even sharper counter-attack and choose instead to listen gently and build up, you beat a sword into a ploughshare. Every time your family or your life becomes a safe, shady place under a vine and fig tree, where people experience rest and hospitality instead of condemnation, Micah's prophecy becomes visible in your street.

And when it feels as if you are the only one in your circle of friends or at your workplace who still takes God's ways seriously, hold on to verse 5. You don't have to be swept along by the course of the majority. Walk with quiet conviction in the name of the LORD your God.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- When you look at the brokenness and unrest in the world (or in your own life), is your outlook shaped more by the visible "heaps of ruins" of Micah 3:12, or by the firm promise of God's coming kingdom in Micah 4:1–4?
- Are there "swords and spears" in your relationships right now – defence mechanisms, sarcasm, old grudges or harsh words – that the Lord is asking you to beat today into "ploughshares and pruning knives" that bring life and healing?
- Look at the eagerness of the nations in verse 2: *"so that he may teach us his ways and we may walk in his paths."* Do you come to your daily quiet time and Bible reading with the same hunger to be taught and changed by God?
- In which specific area of your life is the culture around you currently tempting you to walk in the name of its modern "gods" (status, consumerism, fear), and what would it look like to walk there deliberately in the name of the LORD (v. 5)?

Prayer

Lord of hosts, God of Jacob and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, I praise you that your judgement never has the last word, but that your grace raises up a kingdom of everlasting peace out of the darkest ruins. Thank you for the firm promise that the day is coming when every knee will bow and no nation will lift up the sword against another any more.

Lord, while I wait for that perfect day, I ask that your kingdom may already take shape in my own heart today. Set things right within me. Take the sharp "swords" of my impatience, my self-defence and my critical words, and melt them in the fire of your Spirit into tools that bless, provide and build up.

Make me hungry to sit at your feet every day, so that you can teach me your ways. Even though the world around me runs after perishable idols, give me the grace to walk in your holy name with an undivided heart, today and for ever. Amen.

DAY 8

From Lame Sheep to an Iron Horn: God's Plan Through the Exile

SCRIPTURE

Micah 4:6–13

6 On that day – declares the LORD –
I will gather the lame
and assemble the outcast,
and the one on whom I brought evil.
7 I will make the lame a remnant,
and the one driven far away a mighty nation;
and the LORD will reign over them on Mount Zion
from now on and for ever.
8 And you, tower of the flock,
hill of Daughter Zion,
to you it will come:
the former dominion will come,
the kingdom of Daughter Jerusalem.
9 Now, why do you cry out so loudly?
Is there no king in you?
Has your counsellor perished,
that pain has seized you like a woman giving birth?
10 Writhe and push, Daughter Zion,
like a woman giving birth!
For now you will go out of the city
and live in the open field;
you will come as far as Babylon.
There you will be rescued;
there the LORD will redeem you
from the hand of your enemies.
11 And now many nations
have gathered against you,
who say: "Let her be defiled,
and let our eyes gloat over Zion!"
12 But they do not know the plans of the LORD,
and they do not understand his counsel:
that he has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor.
13 Get up and thresh, Daughter Zion!

For I will make your horn iron,
and your hoofs I will make bronze;
you will crush many peoples.
And I will devote their gain to the LORD,
their wealth to the Lord of all the earth.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

After painting in verses 1 to 5 the breathtaking vision of the "last days" – in which all the nations stream to Zion in peace – Micah brings us back in verses 6 to 13 to the rough road that lies between Judah's present crisis and that final glory. How does a broken, sinful people get from the ruins of Micah 3 to the paradise of Micah 4? Micah's answer is honest and encouraging at once: **the road to glory runs right through the fire of refining and exile, but the Shepherd-King never lets the reins slip from his hand.**

These eight verses fall into three powerful prophetic scenes: the first is introduced by "**On that day**" (*bayyom hahu* – בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא, vv. 6–8), the second by "**Now**" (*'attah* – עַתָּה, vv. 9–10) and the third by "**And now**" (*we'attah*, vv. 11–13).

Historically, Micah lives during the rise of the Assyrian empire (late eighth century BC). In his day **Babylon** was a city under Assyrian domination – its king Merodach-baladan did rebel against Assyria and sent envoys to Hezekiah (2 Kings 20:12) – and by no means the world power it would become more than a century later under Nebuchadnezzar. And yet, by the Spirit of God (v. 10), Micah sees more than a hundred years ahead that Jerusalem would finally be carried off into exile to **Babylon** (586 BC) – and that right there, in the heart of their deepest humiliation, the LORD would redeem them!

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **The lame (*hatstsole'ah* – הַצֹּלֵעָה) made a remnant (*she'erit* – שְׁאֵרִית):** In verses 6 and 7 the LORD promises to gather the sheep that limp or are lame (*tsala'* – the same verb used in Genesis 32:31, Hebrew 32:32, of Jacob limping after his wrestling with God). Normally a leader builds a mighty nation out of the strongest and bravest. God does the exact opposite: he takes the bruised, the scattered and those who have been bowed down under his discipline, and makes *them* his invincible remnant (*she'erit*).
- **Tower of the flock (*migdal 'eder* – מִגְדַּל עֵדֶר) and Ophel (*'ofel* – עֹפֶל):** In verse 8 Micah addresses Jerusalem as *migdal 'eder* ("tower of the flock") and *'ofel* – in our translation "hill", the fortified ridge just south of the temple mount where the royal palaces probably stood. A tower of the flock was a stone watchpost in the field from which the shepherd guarded his sheep against predators. Although David's earthly royal house would soon look like an abandoned watchpost, God promises that *"the former dominion will come"* (the messianic kingship of David's line) to Zion.
- **Birth pains instead of death throes (*chuli wagochi* – חוּלִי וָגֹחִי):** In verses 9 and 10 we hear Jerusalem screaming in terror as the enemy surrounds her. With sharp irony Micah asks: *"Is there no king in you? Has your counsellor* (yo'atsekh – יוֹעֲצֵךְ) *perished …?"* Their earthly kings and political advisers are powerless – but their true King (v. 7) lives! That is why Micah compares their suffering to a woman in labour (*kayyoledah* – כַּיּוֹלֵדָה). Death pains end in a grave, but **birth pains** – however fierce they are – bring forth new life.
- **The plans (*machshevot* – מַחְשְׁבוֹת) and counsel (*'etsah* – עֵצָה) of the LORD (v. 12):** The enemy nations crowding around Jerusalem to destroy her think they are carrying out their own military agenda. But Micah shows the hidden reality behind the scenes: *"they do not know the plans*

of the LORD*, and they do not understand his counsel.*" They think they are coming as reapers to cut Judah down, but God has in fact gathered them like sheaves (*'amir*) on his threshing floor!

- **From cowering flock to threshing ox (v. 13):** Notice the change of imagery. In the last verse the defenceless Daughter Zion is commanded to get up and thresh (*doshi*). In the ancient world oxen threshed grain by trampling over the sheaves on the threshing floor, often pulling a threshing sledge; the horn was the picture of strength (see Deuteronomy 33:17). God makes her horn of **iron** and her hoofs of **bronze.** And the gain (*betsa'* – בָּצַע) that the nations amassed by violence is not kept for self-enrichment but devoted (*charam* – חָרַם) "*to the Lord of all the earth*" (*adon kol ha'arets* – אֲדוֹן כָּל הָאָרֶץ).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's kingdom is built with broken people restored by grace.** The LORD does not reject his sheep because they are lame, wounded or even struck by his own righteous discipline (v. 6). In God's economy weakness is not a disqualification but the place where his power is made perfect (see 2 Corinthians 12:9).

2. **For a child of God, suffering is never a dead end but a birth canal.** Judah first had to be torn away from its false securities in the city and live in the open field on the way to Babylon before it could be redeemed ("*There you will be rescued*" – v. 10). Sometimes God takes us out of our comfort zones into a spiritual "field" where all our human props fall away, so that we can come to know him alone as our Redeemer.

3. **God's sovereign counsel (*'etsah*) rules even over the wickedness of his enemies.** When the powers of darkness conspire against God's people, it looks to human eyes as if evil is winning (v. 11). But according to verse 12, even the enemy unknowingly serves God's higher plan. As at the cross of Golgotha, where the enemies thought they were defeating the Son of God, the Lord carries out his greatest work of salvation precisely through the darkest hour (see Acts 4:27–28).

4. **True victory always ends in devotion to the Lord.** Unlike the leaders of Micah 2 and 3, who put unjust gain (*betsa'*) into their own pockets, the treasures of the nations in verse 13 are devoted to the Lord of all the earth. In the Hebrew text the LORD does this himself ("*And I will devote their gain to the* LORD"); the redeemed people share in his victory and keep nothing of it for themselves.

Living It Out

Micah 4:6–13 speaks today with special power to everyone who feels a huge gap between **God's great promises** for their life and **their present broken reality**.

Perhaps you are reading this devotional feeling, spiritually or emotionally, like the sheep in verse 6: **lame, tired and pushed to the side.** Perhaps you limp because of the hurt other people have caused you, or perhaps you limp because you have had to go through your own wrong choices and the Lord's loving discipline. The enemy loves to whisper to such believers that they are now only of "second-hand" use in God's kingdom. But look at the promise of verse 7: "*I will make the lame a remnant, and the one driven far away a mighty nation.*" The Good Shepherd is not ashamed of your limping walk; he picks you up and builds his future precisely through people who know their own weakness and lean entirely on his grace.

Second, verses 9 to 12 give us new glasses through which to look at our present trials. When a crisis strikes – an illness, a financial setback, or a season in which we are forced out of the safe city of our control into the open field of uncertainty – our first reaction is often panic ("*why do you cry out so loudly?*"). In the storm we forget that our King and our Wonderful Counsellor (Isaiah 9:6, Hebrew 9:5) is still on his throne!

More than that: the Lord invites you today to see that your pain is not the destruction of your life but **birth pains** through which he is bringing forth something new, pure and eternal in your character. The circum-

stances that today feel as though they have conspired to crush you are already lying like sheaves on the threshing floor of God's sovereign plan. In Babylon – at the place where your own strength has completely run out – you will discover that the Lord himself is your Redeemer and your strength.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- In which area of your life do you feel "lame" or broken right now (v. 6), and how does it change your perspective to know that the Lord chooses precisely such people to reveal his power and kingship?
- When unexpected crises strike, do you react as if you have no king and no counsellor (v. 9), or do you remind your soul that Jesus Christ reigns on the throne of your life?
- Is there a "Babylon experience" or an "open field" in your life – a place you would never have chosen to go – where you can look back and say: "There the Lord truly set me free from my idols and fears" (v. 10)?
- Which difficult situation or opposition in your life seems to be gaining the upper hand right now (v. 11), where you need to hold on to the truth of verse 12: that the Lord's plans and counsel are completely in control?

Prayer

Sovereign Lord, King of Zion and Shepherd of my soul, I thank you for the immense comfort of your word today. Thank you that you are not only a God for the strong and the perfect, but that you seek out the lame, the wounded and the scattered sheep and gather them in your arms.

Lord, you know the places in my life where I am limping today and where I am bowed down under my own shortcomings or hurts. By your grace, turn my weakness into a testimony of your power. Forgive me for the times when, in distress, I cry out as if I had no King and no Counsellor. Help me to remember that no enemy and no trial can move outside your plan.

Even when you lead me out of my earthly comfort zones to places where I can only trust in you, let me firmly believe that it is right there that you will meet me and redeem me. Make me strong in your strength today, and let everything I overcome and receive by your grace be devoted only to your honour – to you, the Lord of all the earth. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 9

The Ruler from Bethlehem Ephrathah: Our Peace from Ancient Days

SCRIPTURE

Micah 4:14 – 5:4

14 Now gather your troops, daughter of troops!
A siege has been laid against us;
with the staff they strike the judge of Israel
on the cheek. (*English Bibles*: 5:1)
1 But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah,
too small to be among the clans of Judah,
from you one will come out for me
to be ruler in Israel;
his origins are from of old,
from ancient days. (*English Bibles*: 5:2; *from here on add one to the verse number*)
2 Therefore he will give them up
until the time when she who is in labour has given birth;
then the rest of his brothers will return
to the children of Israel.
3 He will stand and shepherd
in the strength of the LORD,
in the majesty of the name of the LORD his God.
And they will dwell secure,
for now he will be great
to the ends of the earth.
4 And this one will be peace.
When Assyria comes into our land
and when he treads in our fortresses,
we will raise against him seven shepherds
and eight princes of men.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

This passage is one of the highest peaks of Messianic prophecy in the whole Old Testament. When, centuries later, the wise men from the East arrive in Jerusalem and ask King Herod where the newborn King of the Jews is to be found (Matthew 2:1–6), the scribes quote these very words of Micah without hesitation.

(A note on verse numbers: today's passage is 4:14–5:4a in the Hebrew text, which we follow; English Bibles number it 5:1–5a. From 5:1 onward in this chapter, add one to our verse number to find it in an English Bible.)

To appreciate the beauty of this diamond, though, we first have to see it against the pitch-black velvet of the opening verse, 4:14 (English 5:1). Micah sketches the moment of Judah's deepest political and national humiliation. Jerusalem is addressed as "*daughter of troops*" (*bat gedud*), huddling in fear behind her walls while the enemy lays a siege (*matsor*) around the city. In the ancient Near East it was a deep, public humiliation to be struck on the cheek or jaw (*lechi*) with a stick in front of others (cf. 1 Kings 22:24; Job 16:10) – all the more for a king or "judge" (*shofet*). It was visible proof that the ruler was utterly powerless to protect his people.

Against the proud capital Jerusalem, whose earthly king is struck on the cheek and humiliated, God now swings his camera away to a forgotten country village less than ten kilometres south of Jerusalem: **Bethlehem Ephrathah**. When David's royal house in Jerusalem had decayed over the centuries into pride, corruption and abuse of power (as we saw in Micah 1–3), God goes back to the humble roots where David was first called as a shepherd boy (1 Samuel 16). Where human kingship ends in disgrace, God's eternal kingship begins.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **The wordplay on "troops" (*titgodedi bat gedud* – תִּתְגֹּדְדִי בַת גְּדוּד):** In the first verse (4:14; English 5:1) Micah uses a sharp Hebrew wordplay. The root *gadad* has two related meanings: "to band together in troops" and "to gash yourself with knives" (as pagan mourners did in times of utter despair). Our translation reads: "*Now gather your troops, daughter of troops!*" – but the second meaning echoes underneath. Jerusalem, which like a raiding band exploited its own poor (Micah 2–3), now sits trapped and gashes herself in grief and mortal fear.

- **Judge (*shofet* – שֹׁפֵט) and Bethlehem (*Beit Lechem* – בֵּית לֶחֶם):** Notice the echo in the Hebrew between the *shofet* (judge, ruler) who is struck on the *lechi* (cheek, jaw) and *Beit Lechem*, "**House of Bread**". The name *Ephrathah* is usually linked with "**fruitfulness**". Out of the place of simple bread and fruitfulness comes the true Bread of Life.

- **Small (*tsa'ir* – צָעִיר) among the clans (*be'alfei Yehudah* – בְּאַלְפֵי יְהוּדָה):** Bethlehem was so insignificant that it does not even appear in the Hebrew text of the list of Judah's towns in Joshua 15 (only the Greek translation, the Septuagint, names it at Joshua 15:59). The word *tsa'ir* means not only geographically small but also "the youngest, least, most insignificant" (the same word Gideon uses of himself in Judges 6:15). God deliberately chooses what is lowly in the world's eyes to put the mighty to shame.

- **From of old, from ancient days (*miqqedem mimei 'olam* – מִקֶּדֶם מִימֵי עוֹלָם):** In 5:1 (English 5:2) our translation reads: "*his origins are from of old, from ancient days*." The word *'olam* can mean "the distant past", but also "eternity". In 7:14 *kimei 'olam* clearly means "as in ancient days"; here, however, *mimei 'olam* can just as well mean "from the days of eternity". These words breathe a mystery that rises far above an ordinary earthly descendant of David. On the one hand his origin lies in the ancient covenant promise to David (*miqqedem*); on the other hand the

phrase *mimei 'olam* reaches back into the eternity before creation itself (cf. Proverbs 8:22–23; John 1:1–2). The Baby born in Bethlehem in time is at the same time the eternal Son who exists before all time!

- **He will stand and shepherd (*we'amad wera'ah* – וְעָמַד וְרָעָה):** Unlike the frightened kings of Judah, who hid or collapsed in times of crisis, this Ruler will **stand** (*'amad* – unshaken, watchful and decisive) and **shepherd** his people (*ra'ah*). As a result his flock will *"dwell secure"* (*weyashavu* – וְיָשְׁבוּ – literally: they will be able to sit down at rest, without fear of predators).
- **And this one will be peace (*wehayah zeh shalom* – וְהָיָה זֶה שָׁלוֹם):** Look very carefully at the wording of verse 4a (English 5:5a). The text does not merely say that the Messiah will *bring* peace or *bring about* peace. It says literally: *"And this one will be peace."* **This One (*zeh*) is himself the Peace (*shalom*)!** Peace is not a political treaty; Peace is a Person.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's greatest acts of salvation begin in the most unlikely places:** The world looks for rescue in the palaces of Jerusalem, Assyria or today's centres of power; God sends his Ruler out of the quiet streets of Bethlehem. When God works, he needs neither human prestige nor impressive resources.
2. **The two natures of Christ – truly man and truly God:** Micah holds two wonderful truths side by side: the Messiah is born as a real human being in a particular Jewish village, of a woman in labour (5:2; English 5:3) – and his origin lies in eternity (*mimei 'olam*). More than that: the earthly judge struck on the cheek with a staff in 4:14 finds his deepest fulfilment when Jesus Christ – the true King of Israel – was struck in the face during his trial and beaten on the head with a reed (Matthew 26:67; 27:30), to take our shame upon himself.

3. **The true Shepherd rules by the strength and majesty of God, not by violence:** In contrast to the leaders of Micah 3, who slaughtered and devoured the sheep, Christ shepherds his flock in the strength (*'oz*) and in the majesty of the name (*ge'on shem*) of his Father. His rule extends not just over a small patch of land in the Near East, but "to *the ends of the earth*".
4. **True *shalom* is inseparable from the presence of Jesus:** Paul reaches back to this thought when he writes in **Ephesians 2:14** that Christ himself is our peace. Where Christ reigns as Shepherd and King, there the soul rests in complete security.

Living It Out

Micah 4:14–5:4a (English 5:1–5a) meets us today exactly where our own earthly securities are under siege. We all know those seasons of life when it feels as if a siege has been laid against us – when financial pressure, health crises, strain in a marriage or uncertainty about the future press in on us from every side. In such moments our own "inner ruler" (our self-confidence, our clever plans and our ability to keep things under control) is, as it were, struck on the cheek. We discover how defenceless we really are.

Precisely there Micah calls us to turn our eyes away from our own besieged "Jerusalem" and to look at **Bethlehem**.

First, this passage frees us from the lie that we have to be "big" or "impressive" before God can use us. Do your life, your gifts, your faith or your daily obedience sometimes feel like Bethlehem – "*too small to be among the clans of Judah*"? Do not despise small things. The God of the Bible specialises in doing eternal work through "Bethlehem places" and humble hearts.

Second, verses 3 and 4a (English 5:4–5a) change the way we look for **peace**. How often do we tell ourselves: "*I'll have peace once this problem is solved, once my bank account is healthy, or once that difficult person has changed*"?

As long as your peace depends on the absence of storms, you will always stay anxious. But Micah shows us the secret of how sheep can "dwell secure" even in a dangerous world: they look up and see that their Shepherd is **standing** (*we'amad*). While we sit and rest, Jesus Christ stands guard in the invincible strength of God.

You don't have to wait today for your circumstances to turn peaceful first; **he is your Peace.** When he stands in the middle of your boat, your heart can dwell secure, even while the storm still rages outside.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Is there an area of your life (or of your ministry and calling) that feels like "Bethlehem" to you – too small, too insignificant or too weak to make a difference? How does God's choice of Bethlehem encourage you today?
- What is your inner peace built on at the moment: on your outward circumstances going well, or on the Person of Jesus Christ, who is himself your Peace ("*And this one will be peace*")?
- Look at the picture in verse 3 (English 5:4): the Shepherd **stands** and shepherds in the strength of the LORD, so that the flock can **dwell secure** (literally: sit). Are you anxiously trying to man the watch post yourself through worry and control, instead of resting under his shepherd's staff?
- How does your response to today's crises show the world around you that your King is not a powerless earthly leader, but the eternal Ruler whose power reaches to the ends of the earth?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus Christ, Son of David and eternal King from Bethlehem Ephrathah, I worship you today with all my heart! When our earthly strength was broken and our human pride plunged into disgrace, you*

stepped out of eternity into our fragile world. You allowed yourself to be struck on the cheek and crowned with thorns, so that I may live for ever as a redeemed child of God.

Thank you that you do not despise small and lowly places; come and live again today in the "Bethlehem" of my broken and dependent heart. My Good Shepherd, thank you that you stand today and watch over my life in the almighty power and majesty of the Father. Forgive me for all the times I went looking for peace in changing circumstances, while you yourself are my Peace.

Teach my soul to dwell secure under your shepherd's staff today. Be the Peace in my thoughts, in my home and in every storm that beats against my walls. I rest in you alone. Amen.

DAY 10

The Remnant like Dew and the Cleansing of False Supports

SCRIPTURE

Micah 5:4–14

4 And this one will be peace.
When Assyria comes into our land
and when he treads in our fortresses,
we will raise against him seven shepherds
and eight princes of men.
5 They will shepherd the land of Assyria with the sword,
and the land of Nimrod at its gates.
And he will rescue us from Assyria
when he comes into our land
and when he treads within our borders.
6 And the remnant of Jacob will be
in the midst of many peoples
like dew from the LORD,
like showers on the grass,
which does not wait for a man
nor hope for the children of men.
7 And the remnant of Jacob will be among the nations,
in the midst of many peoples,
like a lion among the animals of the forest,
like a young lion among the flocks of sheep,
which, if it passes through, tramples and tears,
and there is no one to rescue.
8 Your hand will be lifted high over your adversaries,
and all your enemies will be cut off.
9 And it will come to pass on that day – declares the LORD –
that I will cut off your horses from among you
and make your chariots perish.
10 I will cut off the cities of your land
and tear down all your fortresses.
11 I will cut off sorceries from your hand,
and you will have no more fortune-tellers.
12 I will cut off your carved images
and your sacred pillars from among you,

and you will no longer bow down
to the work of your hands.
13 I will uproot your Asherah poles from among you
and destroy your cities.
14 And in anger and in wrath I will execute vengeance
on the nations that did not listen.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday Micah fixed our eyes on the Person of the Messiah – the Ruler from Bethlehem who is himself our *Peace* (*shalom*): *"And this one will be peace."* In verses 4b to 14 (Hebrew numbering; English Bibles 5:5b–15) the prophet now shows how the coming of this Shepherd-King radically changes the life and calling of his people on earth.

Historically, **Assyria** and the "**land of Nimrod**" (in Genesis 10:8–11 the primeval symbol of human rebellion and violent empire-building) stand here for every world power that sets itself up against God's kingdom. When such an enemy attacks, God's remnant is no longer defenceless. Under the authority of the one true Shepherd (5:3; English 5:4) God raises up enough leadership to stop the onslaught.

Next, in verses 6–7 (English 5:7–8), Micah paints the twofold calling of the faithful remnant among the nations: they are at the same time **like refreshing dew** and **like an unconquerable lion**. But the chapter ends with a surprising turn (vv. 9–13; English 5:10–14). Before God judges the disobedient nations, he first carries out a radical **inner cleansing** among his own people. He cuts away all the military and religious crutches Judah had leaned on for so long, so that they will trust in him alone.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Seven shepherds and eight princes (*shiv'ah ro'im ushemonah nesikhei adam* – שִׁבְעָה רֹעִים וּשְׁמֹנָה נְסִיכֵי אָדָם):** This numerical saying ("X, even X+1" – cf. Proverbs 30:18; Amos 1:3) is a Hebrew idiom for **overflowing fullness**. "Seven" is the number of divine perfection; "eight" means there will be even more than enough spiritual leaders and resources when the crisis strikes.

- **Like dew from the LORD (*ketal me'et YHWH* – כְּטַל מֵאֵת יְהוָה):** During the long, dry summer months in Israel (roughly May to October) almost no rain falls; the survival of the crops depends largely on the heavy night dew that rolls in from the Mediterranean. Micah stresses that the dew and the showers (*revivim*) are something *"which does not wait for a man nor hope for the children of men"*. No king or engineer can command the dew to fall; it is pure grace from above. In the same way God's remnant is an unexpected, life-giving blessing among the nations, purely through God's sovereign working.

- **Like a lion (*ke'aryeh* – כְּאַרְיֵה):** Right next to the gentle picture of dew Micah sets the majestic picture of a lion and a young lion (*kefir*). To those who hunger for God's grace, his people are like refreshing dew; but in the face of spiritual deception and rebellion, the truth of God's kingdom stands with royal, unstoppable authority (cf. 2 Corinthians 2:15–16).

- **The fourfold "I will cut off" (*wehikhratti* – וְהִכְרַתִּי):** In verses 9 to 12 (English 5:10–13) the LORD uses the forceful verb *hikhratti* ("I will cut off") four times, followed by *wenatashti* ("I will uproot", v. 13). It is the same verb used when a covenant is "cut" (made), and also for cutting down a tree (cf. Jeremiah 10:3). Notice the two groups of false supports that God cuts away from his people:

1. **Military self-confidence:** horses (*susim*), chariots (*merkavot*) and fortresses (*mivtsarim*). (Deuteronomy 17:16 had already forbidden Israel's kings to keep many horses, so that they would not boast in hu-

man power.)

2. **Spiritual manipulation and idolatry:** sorceries (*keshafim* – attempts to control the future apart from God), fortune-tellers (*me'onenim*), carved images (*pesilim*), sacred pillars (*matsevot*) and Asherah poles (*asherim*).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's people carry a twofold witness in the world – gentle grace and unshakeable truth:** Like dew, the church of Christ brings refreshment, healing and gospel hope to a parched world. Like a lion, however, the church refuses to bow to the intimidation of earthly ideologies, because we share in the victory of the Lion of the tribe of Judah.
2. **True spiritual fruit is never the result of human manipulation:** Just as the dew "does not wait for a man" or depend on human permission (v. 6; English 5:7), the spread of God's kingdom rests not on human marketing plans or political power, but on the quiet, unstoppable working of the Holy Spirit.
3. **God's most gracious work in our lives sometimes looks like a loss:** When the LORD says in verses 9–13 (English 5:10–14) that he will cut off our horses, our fortresses and our idols from among us, he does not speak out of hatred for his people but out of covenant love. Everything we lean on that keeps us from leaning wholly on the Lord has to be removed by his surgeon's hand.
4. **Our greatest temptation is to bow down to "the work of your hands" (v. 12; English 5:13):** Whether it is an ancient wooden image or our modern achievements, technology, savings or intellect – as soon as we find our security in something we have made or built ourselves, we commit idolatry.

Living It Out

Micah 5:4b–14 (English 5:5b–15) calls us today to look both at our **influence outward** and at our **supports inward**.

Think first of the lovely picture of the **dew from the** LORD (v. 6; English 5:7). Dew doesn't fall with thunderclaps and a lot of noise; it forms in the stillness of the night and every morning sets millions of tiny drops of life on dry blades of grass. Are the people around you – your family, your colleagues, the shop assistant you talk to – spiritually refreshed after being with you? Or do our words sometimes leave them more scorched and tired? At the same time, the picture of the **lion** reminds us that kindness never means weakness. We can be gentle as dew in the way we treat people, while standing as fearless as a lion against sin and temptation.

Second, verses 9 to 13 (English 5:10–14) challenge us to understand God's "**pruning knife of liberation**" in our lives. Have you ever experienced the Lord suddenly taking away one of your "horses or chariots" – a source of income you relied on, a position that gave you standing, or a human plan that was supposed to guarantee your security? Our first reaction is often fear: "*Lord, why are you tearing down my fortresses?*"

But look at the Father's heart in verse 12 (English 5:13): "***and you will no longer bow down to the work of your hands.***" God never pulls a false crutch from under our arms to make us fall; he takes it away so that we learn again how safe it is to lean on the Shepherd from Bethlehem alone. When your own "horses and fortresses" fall away, you are not defenceless – you are finally free from idolatry.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Looking at your daily walk at home and at work, where do you need to be more like "**dew from the** LORD" (quiet, refreshing and gracious), and where do you need to act more like **the lion** (brave and principled)?
- Which modern "horses and chariots" (financial buffers, your own expertise, status or control) give you a false sense of independence, so that you pray less honestly and less dependently?

- Is there any form of subtle "sorcery" in your life (v. 11; English 5:12) – not necessarily the occult, but attempts to force the future through anxious control, superstition or human manipulation instead of trusting God?
- Look back on a season when the Lord took an earthly "fortress" or support out of your hand. How can you see today that through it he set you free from the trap of bowing down to "the work of your hands"?

Prayer

> *Almighty Lord and faithful Father, I thank you that you never leave us alone when the attacks of the world rise against us like a flood, but that Jesus Christ, our Peace, watches over us as Victor.*
>
> *Lord, make my life today like the dew of heaven on a dry and weary world. Let my words, my attitude and my actions bring refreshment and new courage to everyone who crosses my path today, without my waiting for human honour or recognition. At the same time give me the lion-hearted courage of your Spirit never to give in to evil or compromise.*
>
> *And Lord, today I give you permission to cleanse my heart. Where I still trust in my own "horses and chariots" or quietly kneel before the work of my own hands, cut those false supports away by your grace. I want to boast in no other fortress than in you alone. In the name of Jesus, Amen.*

DAY 11

The Case before the Mountains and What the LORD Seeks from You

SCRIPTURE

Micah 6:1–8

[1] Hear, please, what the LORD says:
Get up, plead the case before the mountains,
and let the hills hear your voice!
[2] Hear, you mountains, the case of the LORD,
you enduring ones, foundations of the earth!
For the LORD has a case against his people,
and with Israel he will argue it.
[3] My people, what have I done to you?
How have I wearied you? Answer me!
[4] For I brought you up from the land of Egypt,
and from the house of slaves I redeemed you;
and I sent before you
Moses, Aaron and Miriam.
[5] My people, remember
what Balak king of Moab planned,
and what Balaam son of Beor answered him –
from Shittim to Gilgal –
so that you may know the righteous acts of the LORD.
[6] With what shall I come before the LORD,
and bow down before God on high?
Shall I come before him with burnt offerings,
with calves a year old?
[7] Will the LORD be pleased with thousands of rams,
with ten thousand rivers of oil?
Shall I give my firstborn for my rebellion,
the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul?
[8] He has told you, O man, what is good,
and what the LORD seeks from you:
only to do justice,
to love faithful love,
and to walk humbly with your God.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With the call *"Hear, please"* (*shim'u na*) in Micah 6:1 the third and last major section of the book begins (chapters 6–7). Just as in 1:2 and 3:1, we are once again led into a heavenly courtroom. This time the LORD summons the **mountains and the age-old hills** as jury and witnesses in his covenant lawsuit (*riv*, "case") against Israel. Why the mountains? Because those immovable peaks were already standing there when God made his covenant with Israel, when he led them into the Promised Land, and when the people broke their covenant promises for centuries (cf. Deuteronomy 32:1).

What happens in verse 3, however, is entirely unexpected. Instead of the Almighty Judge reading out his charge sheet with thunderclaps, we hear the wounded voice of a loving Father and covenant Bridegroom: "***My people, what have I done to you? How have I wearied you? Answer me!***" (*'ammi* – "my people"). Israel behaves as if serving the LORD were an unbearable burden, but the LORD points back to their history: he never laid slavery on them – he redeemed them *out of* the house of slaves (*beit 'avadim*)! From the exodus out of Egypt, through the wilderness where he turned the curses of Balak and Balaam into blessings (Numbers 22–24), to the crossing of the Jordan between **Shittim** (the last camp in Moab) and **Gilgal** (the first camp in Canaan; Joshua 3–4), his whole journey with them was one long chain of saving acts.

In verses 6 and 7 we hear the voice of a guilty worshipper who realises the LORD is in the right. But look at how the human religious instinct works: the speaker thinks he can buy back God's favour by piling ever greater outward offerings on the altar – from calves a year old to thousands of rams, ten thousand rivers of oil, and finally the horrific pagan practice of child sacrifice (of which even King Ahaz of Judah was guilty; 2 Kings 16:3).

Then the hammer of God's unforgettable answer falls in verse 8: what the LORD *seeks* (*doresh*) from you is not your ritual bribes; he seeks **your heart and the way you live**.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **The righteous acts of the LORD (*tsidqot* YHWH – צִדְקוֹת יְהוָה):** In verse 5 God calls the people to remember his *tsidqot*. In the Old Testament the plural *tsidqot* does not mean a cold, punishing justice but **God's saving covenant faithfulness** – all the concrete acts by which he rescued his people from their enemies and kept his promises.
- **To come before the LORD (*aqaddem* – אֲקַדֵּם, from *qadam*):** When the questioner asks in verse 6, "*With what shall I come before the* LORD", the verb *qadam* means to go to meet someone or to appear before him – here, as the rest of the verse shows, with a gift in hand to win his favour or calm his anger. It betrays a pagan view of God, in which God is a fickle ruler who has to be bought off with costly offerings.
- **The threefold calling of verse 8 (*mishpat*, *chesed*, *hatsnea' lekhet*):** In one of the best-known verses of the Hebrew Bible, Micah sums up the essence of true faith in three inseparable ideas:

1. **To do justice (*'asot mishpat* – עֲשׂוֹת מִשְׁפָּט):** To stand up actively for what is right and fair, especially for those who are being exploited. It is not merely a feeling but something you *do* (*'asah*).
2. **To love faithful love (*ahavat chesed* – וְאַהֲבַת חֶסֶד):** Many English Bibles say "to love kindness" or "to love mercy", but literally the text says: "**to love *chesed***" – and so our translation reads: "*to love faithful love*". *Chesed* is far more than kindness. It is one of the richest words in Hebrew: loyal covenant love, faithfulness, mercy and undeserved grace. And it is the very word Micah uses for God himself at the end of the book: "*he delights in faithful love*" (7:18) and "*faithful love to Abraham*" (7:20). God asks us to love what he himself delights in. We are not just to show *chesed* out of duty; we are to have a deep *love and joy* in being gracious!
3. **To walk humbly with your God (*wehatsnea' lekhet 'im Eloheikha* – וְהַצְנֵעַ לֶכֶת עִם אֱלֹהֶיךָ):** The rare verb *tsana'* occurs in the Old Testament only here and in Proverbs 11:2 (with the modest is wisdom). It means to

walk with God humbly, attentively, without show and with a listening heart.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **True obedience is born of grateful remembrance of God's grace:** Before God says in verse 8 how his people should live, he first reminds them in verses 4 and 5 how he rescued them from slavery and carried them from Shittim to Gilgal. When we forget what God has redeemed us from, his commands begin to feel like a wearying burden (v. 3).
2. **No amount of religious activity can make up for a disobedient heart:** We are willing to pay almost any outward price – time, money, church busyness or extreme sacrifices (vv. 6–7) – as long as we can keep control over our own lives. But God cannot be bribed; everything in the universe already belongs to him (Psalm 50:9–12).
3. **Biblical faith unites social justice, inner mercy and personal fellowship with God:** Micah 6:8 keeps us from dividing the spiritual life into compartments. You cannot claim to "walk humbly with your God" while you wrong your neighbour (against *mishpat*) or live without grace (*chesed*). Likewise, human charity without a humble walk with God soon turns into self-righteous pride. Jesus himself confirms this trio in **Matthew 23:23** as what he calls the weightier things of the law – justice, mercy and faithfulness.
4. **Christ has fulfilled what we could never give:** The desperate question of verse 7 (*"Shall I give my firstborn for my rebellion"*) could not be answered by any human being. But in the fullness of time God the Father did what no one else could do: he gave his own only Son for our rebellion, so that we might be acquitted and enabled by his Spirit to walk with him in *mishpat*, *chesed* and humility.

Living It Out

Micah 6:1–8 touches one of the deepest misunderstandings in our spiritual lives: the idea that the Lord is a demanding master who wants to **weary** us (v. 3), and that we have to earn his favour through **impressive religious performance** (vv. 6–7).

Think first of the moving question the Lord asks you today – "My child," he says: "*How have I wearied you*?" Sometimes we become spiritually exhausted, not because the yoke of Jesus is heavy (Matthew 11:28–30), but because we are trying to keep a religious show going that he never asked of us. When your faith feels cold or heavy, take Micah's advice in verse 5: **travel back in your memory from Shittim to Gilgal.** Think back to the "Egypt" the Lord rescued you from. Think of the times the enemy wanted to curse or destroy you, and how the Lord turned it into blessing behind the scenes. Gratitude is the fuel that drives out spiritual weariness.

Second, verse 8 frees us from complicated religious riddles: "*He has told you, O man, what is good.*" God's will for you today is not a secret reserved for spiritual giants. It lies on three simple tracks right in front of your feet:

- **Do justice (*mishpat*):** Be honest in your work today, keep your promises, pay what you owe, and use your voice to stand up for the one who cannot fight for himself.
- **Love *chesed*:** Don't forgive or help only out of duty; ask the Lord to make you fall in love with grace. Be the person with whom others find gentle hands, loyal friendship and second chances.
- **Walk humbly with your God:** Not ahead of God in self-willed haste, and not far behind him in sluggishness, but *with him* – step by step, listening, aware of your own smallness and full of wonder that God on high chooses to walk beside you.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Does your relationship with the Lord feel to you at the moment like joyful freedom or like something that "wearies" you (v. 3)? Which personal "from Shittim to Gilgal" moments (when God carried you through in the past) do you need to call to mind again today?
- Do you sometimes try to "negotiate" with God like the speaker in verses 6–7 – by offering outward religious duties, money or busy activity instead of surrendering a specific area of disobedience in your heart?
- Of the three commands in verse 8 – **to do justice**, **to love faithful love (*chesed*)** and **to walk humbly with your God** – which comes most easily to you, and which is being neglected in your daily life right now?
- What does it look like in practice for you today to walk with God *humbly and without outward show* (*hatsnea'*) through your ordinary routine and conversations?

Prayer

Faithful and merciful Father, God on high who nevertheless comes so near to me, I bow before you today in wonder. Forgive me for all the times I grumbled in my heart as if serving you were a heavy burden, when you have in fact redeemed me from the house of slavery to sin and crowned my life with your righteous acts of rescue.

Thank you that I don't have to try to buy your love with my own broken works or offerings, because you gave your own firstborn Son, Jesus Christ, on the cross for the sin of my soul.

Lord, write the words of Micah 6:8 deep on the tablets of my heart today. Teach me to do justice in every decision and every transaction. Fill me with a deep love for mercy and covenant faithfulness, so that I may be a mirror of your grace to the people around me. Above all, take me by the hand today and teach me to walk with you quietly, attentively and humbly in every step. In the precious name of Jesus, Amen.

DAY 12

The Rod over the City: False Scales and Fruitless Labour

SCRIPTURE

Micah 6:9–16

9 The voice of the LORD calls out to the city –
and it is wisdom to see your name:
Hear the rod, and the one who appointed it!
10 Are there still in the house of the wicked
treasures of wickedness,
and the short measure that is cursed?
11 Can I count anyone pure with wicked scales
and with a bag of deceitful weights?
12 Her rich men are full of violence,
her inhabitants speak falsehood,
and their tongue is deceit in their mouth.
13 So I too have begun to strike you,
to make you desolate because of your sins.
14 You will eat, but not be satisfied,
and the hunger will be inside you;
you will put things aside, but not save them,
and what you save I will give to the sword.
15 You will sow, but not reap;
you will tread olives, but not anoint yourself with oil,
and grapes for new wine, but not drink wine.
16 The statutes of Omri are kept,
and all the practices of the house of Ahab,
and you walk in their counsels;
so I will make you a desolation,
and her inhabitants something to hiss at;
and you will bear the reproach of my people.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday, in Micah 6:8, we heard the beautiful golden standard of the Lord's heart: "*only to do justice, to love faithful love, and to walk humbly with your God*" – justice (*mishpat*), merciful, loyal love (*chesed*), and a humble walk with God. In verses 9 to 16 the Lord, as it were, carries this measuring line down from the country hills straight into the busy market squares and storehouses of Jerusalem. What he finds there is the exact opposite of verse 8.

Instead of justice (*mishpat*), the city's trade teems with fraud and rigged scales (vv. 10–11). Instead of faithful love (*chesed*), the rich elite are "*full of violence*" and deceit towards their defenceless customers (v. 12). And instead of walking humbly with the LORD, Judah deliberately walks in the corrupt political and economic footsteps of King **Omri and Ahab** of the northern kingdom (v. 16).

Omri and his son Ahab (who was married to the Phoenician princess Jezebel) were, in worldly terms, extremely successful rulers. They built the capital Samaria, made international trade agreements and created a period of unprecedented economic prosperity for the elite. But spiritually and morally they ruined the nation by bringing in the worship of Baal and robbing ordinary citizens of their land with false testimony and violence (like Naboth in 1 Kings 21). Through marriage ties between the royal houses (Ahab's daughter Athaliah married Jehoram, king of Judah; 2 Kings 8:18) this poison flowed straight into Jerusalem's veins.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Sound wisdom (*tushiyyah* – תּוּשִׁיָּה):** In verse 9 Micah declares: "*it is wisdom to see your name*", and calls the city to listen to God's disciplining rod (*matteh* – מַטֶּה). The Hebrew text literally says "see" (*yir'eh*); many interpreters, with a small change, read *yir'at*: 'it is wisdom to fear your name'. Both come to the same thing – to recognise the LORD and to hon-

our him. The word *tushiyyah* (found mainly in Proverbs and Job) does not mean mere academic cleverness, but **sound, practical wisdom for life that brings real success and preservation**. The merchants of Jerusalem thought it "clever" to fake their scales, but true *tushiyyah* lies in reverence for God's character.

- **The lean ephah (*efat razon* – אֵיפַת רָזוֹן) and deceitful weights (*avnei mirmah* – אַבְנֵי מִרְמָה):** In a time before coined money, grain was measured out in a basket (the *ephah* – by common estimates around 22 litres; estimates vary) and silver was weighed on scales (*moznayim*) against stone weights (*avanim*). Our translation calls the "lean ephah" *"the short measure that is cursed"*. Dishonest traders used a smaller, "lean" *ephah* when they sold grain to the poor, and carried a bag with two sets of stone weights on their belt: heavier stones when they received silver from a buyer, lighter ones when they paid out themselves (cf. Deuteronomy 25:13–15; Proverbs 11:1).
- **The curses of futility (*yeshach* – יֶשַׁח):** Verses 14 and 15 echo the so-called **covenant curses of futility** in Leviticus 26 and Deuteronomy 28:30–40. They will eat, but their stomachs will stay empty: *"the hunger will be inside you"*. The word *yeshach* occurs only here in the Bible; its meaning is guessed from the context – probably a gnawing emptiness or hunger deep inside the body (some think of stomach pains). They will sow, tread olives for oil and grapes for new wine (*tirosh*), but never enjoy the fruit.
- **The statutes of Omri (*chuqqot 'omri* – חֻקּוֹת עָמְרִי):** Notice the cutting irony in verse 16. The word *chuqqot* (statutes, decrees) is normally used for the holy laws of the LORD. Judah threw God's statutes overboard and instead kept the "statutes of Omri" – the unwritten business rules of greed, abuse of power and religious compromise – with religious zeal!

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God is intimately involved in our everyday money matters and business ethics.** The Lord does not confine his holiness to the temple courts; he looks right inside the weight-bag and the grain measure in the market (vv. 10–11). To God a dishonest invoice, a hidden defect in a sale or the exploitation of a buyer is as abhorrent as an idol.
2. **God's disciplining "rod" is a gracious warning before final judgement.** When verse 9 calls out, *"Hear the rod, and the one who appointed it!"*, it reminds us that economic setbacks, unrest and social upheaval are not simply "chance accidents". They are God's loving megaphone, calling a people to stop and turn back before it is too late.
3. **Wealth gained without God and through dishonesty loses its power to satisfy.** Verses 14 and 15 describe the deepest tragedy of sin: **chronic unfulfilment**. You can fill your barns with dishonest profit, but God can withdraw the blessing and joy from it, so that in the midst of plenty you are left with a gnawing inner hunger (*yeshach*) (cf. Haggai 1:6; Ecclesiastes 5:9, English 5:10).
4. **In the end you become like the role models whose "counsels" you follow.** Judah thought it could copy the prosperity of Omri and Ahab without sharing their downfall. But whoever walks in Ahab's counsel ends in Ahab's ruin (v. 16).

Living It Out

Micah 6:9–16 forces us to carry our faith from the church pew to our **workbench, our tax returns, our contracts and our everyday words**.

First, the picture of the **"wicked scales" and the "lean ephah"** (vv. 10–11) calls for radical self-examination. We may no longer weigh grain against stones, but every one of us handles "scales" every day.

- How do you weigh out your time and energy for your employer or your customers: do you give a full "ephah" of honest work, or do you deliver a "short measure" while demanding full pay?
- Do we sometimes use **two sets of weights** in our relationships – a heavy, strict standard by which we weigh and condemn other people's faults, and a very light, forgiving one by which we weigh our own?

Second, verses 14 and 15 explain why so many people in our modern consumer culture are exhausted and yet empty: *"You will eat, but not be satisfied" ... "You will sow, but not reap"*. When we live by the "statutes of Omri" – when we chase status, profit and self-gratification outside the will of God – we end up on a spiritual treadmill. We work harder, buy more and collect more, but peace slips through our fingers like sand. True satisfaction never lies in *how much* we gather, but in the LORD's blessing on a righteous and contented life (Proverbs 10:22).

Finally, verse 9 invites us to true wisdom (*tushiyyah*): **to hear the rod**. When the Lord allows our own plans to run aground, or we pass through a hard season of discipline, do not harden your heart or merely complain about the pain. Ask with a soft heart: *Lord, what do you want to teach me through this rod? Where are you calling me back to your heart?*

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If the Lord walked today through the "house" of your finances, your work ethic and your daily communication (vv. 10–12), would he find a hidden "lean ephah" or half-truth he wants to cleanse you of?
- Do you sometimes use double scales in your judgement of people – strict and merciless towards the weaknesses of others, but lenient towards your own?
- Are you experiencing, in any area of your life, the kind of "eating without being satisfied" or restless chasing that verses 14–15 describe? How might that be a sign that you are trying to find satisfaction in things that only God's presence can give?

- Which modern "statutes" of Omri and Ahab (unwritten rules in your industry or culture that say you must compromise to get ahead) are currently pressing you to conform?

Prayer

> *Holy and true God, before whose eyes nothing is hidden, today I bow in deep reverence before your name. Give me that true wisdom which fears your name and is willing to listen to your voice – even when you speak to me through your loving discipline.*
>
> *Lord, today I invite you into every room of my life, my work and my finances. Remove from my hands and from my heart every kind of "false scale" or "short measure". Make my words pure, my promises reliable and my work honest, even when no one is watching.*
>
> *Keep me from the empty treadmill of this world that chases profit but is never satisfied. Deliver me from the temptation to walk in the counsels of Omri and Ahab. Let your blessing rest on the work of my hands, and be yourself the Bread that satisfies my soul to its depths and the Wine that gladdens my heart. In the name of Jesus Christ, Amen.*

DAY 13

Light in the Darkness: Waiting for the LORD When Everything Crumbles

SCRIPTURE

Micah 7:1–7

1 Woe is me! For I have become
like one gathering summer fruit,
like one gleaning after the grape harvest:
there is no cluster to eat,
no early fig that my soul longs for.
2 The faithful one has perished from the land,
and there is no one upright among people.
They all lie in wait for blood;
each hunts his brother with a net.
3 Their hands are on evil, to do it well:
the official asks, and the judge – for a payment;
and the great man speaks out the craving of his soul;
and so they weave it together.
4 The best of them is like a briar,
the most upright worse than a thorn hedge.
The day of your watchmen, your punishment, has come;
now their confusion will be.
5 Do not trust a friend,
do not rely on a close companion;
from her who lies in your embrace
guard the doors of your mouth.
6 For son treats father with contempt,
daughter rises up against her mother,
daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law;
a man's enemies are the people of his own house.
7 But as for me, I will watch for the LORD;
I will wait for the God of my salvation;
my God will hear me.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With chapter 7 we enter the last, deeply personal movement of the book of Micah. After the prophet has exposed Jerusalem's dishonest trade and corrupt leadership in chapter 6, we now hear in verses 1 to 6 a heart-rending personal lament. Micah walks, as it were, like a hungry traveller late in the summer through the vineyards and fig trees of Judah, looking for just one juicy cluster of grapes or one early fig – just one fruit of true righteousness and covenant faithfulness. But the orchards have been stripped bare.

What Micah sees is a society that has collapsed at every level. In **public life** (vv. 2–4) the official, the judge and the influential rich man work hand in hand to twist justice. Even more shocking, this rot has penetrated the **most intimate family circles** (vv. 5–6): friends betray one another, spouses cannot trust each other, and children rebel against their parents.

And then, in the middle of this suffocating moral night in which every human pillar is collapsing, one of the most beautiful declarations of faith in the whole Bible rings out in verse 7: "***But as for me, I will watch for the*** LORD***; I will wait for the God of my salvation; my God will hear me.***"

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **The early fig (*bikkurah* – בִּכּוּרָה):** In verse 1 Micah longs for a *bikkurah* – the first ripe fig, which appeared on the trees in early June and was considered a great delicacy in ancient Israel (cf. Isaiah 28:4; Hosea 9:10). By the end of the summer harvest in August/September all these choice fruits had long since been picked. It is Micah's picture of a spiritually exhausted nation in which moral integrity has become as rare as a summer fig in autumn.
- **The faithful one (*chasid* – חָסִיד):** In verse 2 Micah mourns: "*The faithful one has perished from the land.*" The word *chasid* is derived directly from *chesed* – the loyal, merciful covenant love the Lord asked of his people

in Micah 6:8! Because the people refused to love *chesed*, there is no *chasid* (no person of grace and faithfulness) left to be found in the streets.

- **"They weave it together" (*waye'abbetuha* – וַיְעַבְּתוּהָ):** At the end of verse 3 Micah uses the rare verb *'avat*, which means to plait or knot ropes or branches tightly together. The official (*sar*), the judge (*shofet*) and the powerful businessman (*gadol*) form a tightly woven syndicate of corruption in which one hand washes the other, so that the ordinary citizen has no chance of justice.
- **Briar (*chedeq* – חֵדֶק) and thorn hedge (*mesukah* – מְסוּכָה):** Farmers in Israel often planted dense hedges of thorn bushes around their vineyards to keep out wild animals. But in verse 4 Micah says that even the "best" leaders of Judah have become like a briar: instead of protecting people, they tear and wound everyone who comes near them for help.
- **Watching (*tsafah* – צָפָה) and waiting in hope (*yachal* – יָחַל):*** ***Look at the two powerful verbs with which Micah describes his position in verse 7.*** Tsafah ***is the word for a watchman standing high on the city wall, shading his eyes with his hand and peering intently at the horizon for the coming of the king.*** Yachal*** means to wait with patient, eager expectation. This is not passive resignation but active, wakeful faith.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **When a society rejects God, trust between people crumbles.** Micah 7:2–6 shows that our horizontal relationships (in the state, in the market and in the family) are held together by our shared reverence for God. When the fear of the LORD disappears, every relationship becomes a power struggle in which even family members exploit one another for their own gain.
2. **Jesus Christ knew the loneliness of Micah 7:6 personally and foretold it for his followers.** In **Matthew 10:35–36** (and Luke 12:53) Jesus quotes Micah 7:6 almost word for word to warn his disciples that faith-

fulness to him can sometimes bring division right into a person's own family. When you choose to stand for God's light in a dark time, it may even provoke resistance from those closest to you.

3. **True faith shines brightest when every outward support falls away.** Notice the turn between verse 6 and verse 7. Micah does not say, "*Because everything around me is collapsing, I might as well give up.*" He says: "***But as for me ...***" (*wa'ani* – וַאֲנִי). When human institutions, leaders and even friends disappoint, the believer is driven back to the only Person who never fails: "*the God of my salvation*" (*Elohei yish'i* – אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי).

4. **God's ear is always open to the lonely righteous person.** In Micah 3:4 we read that the LORD hides his face when corrupt oppressors cry to him. But for the child of God who waits on him in the midst of a crooked generation, the sure promise of verse 7 stands: "***my God will hear me.***"

Living It Out

We live today in a world that often feels just like Micah 7:1–6. When we read the news or look at the decline of integrity in politics, business and society at large, it often feels as if we are walking through a stripped vineyard where truth and faithfulness have become scarce. Sometimes, though, the hurt comes much closer to our own front door: a trusted friend who wounds you behind your back, tension and estrangement within your own family, or a thorny workplace where people wound one another to get to the top.

The great danger in such times is that we become **cynical, bitter and hardened**. When we see how the official, the judge and the great man weave their own interests together, or when we are let down by people close to us, we want to lock our hearts away behind thick walls.

In verse 7 Micah shows us an entirely different way out: **the holy turn of the head**. Instead of fixing your eyes on the briars of human disappointment around you, lift your eyes like a watchman on the wall (*tsafah*): "*But as for me, I will watch for the* LORD."

- If the orchards around you feel bare today and you receive little *chesed* (loyal love) from others, the Lord asks that **you be the early fig (*bikkurah*) and the *chasid* (person of grace)** in your surroundings. Don't wait for others to change before you live out integrity and gentleness.
- If you are going through a season in which people you counted on have let you down, let that pain drive you deeper into the arms of "*the God of my salvation*". People are fragile reeds; even the best person can prick like a thorn when you build your ultimate happiness on them. But the Lord will never betray you, and his ear is wide open to your voice today.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- As Micah walks through the "vineyard" of Judah, he searches in vain for the fruit of *chesed* (vv. 1–2). When weary people deal with you today, do they find in you the refreshing "early fig" of integrity and grace, or the sharp "thorns" of defensiveness and selfishness (v. 4)?
- Has disappointment with leaders, institutions or even people close to you made your heart cynical and distrustful lately? How does verse 7 call you to move from bitterness to hopeful expectation?
- Where in your life are you currently sitting in the tension of verses 5–6 (pain or misunderstanding within close relationships or family), where you need to hold on to the comfort that Jesus himself understands this pain and stands beside you?
- What does it mean for you, practically, to "**watch**" (*tsafah*) for the Lord today like a watchman on the wall, in the middle of a situation that has not yet been resolved?

Prayer

Lord, God of my salvation and my only unshakeable Rock, when the shadows around me grow long and human faithfulness vanishes like mist before the sun, today I deliberately turn my eyes away from the brokenness and look up to you! Keep my heart from growing cold, cynical or bitter when I experience disappointment, dishonesty or broken relationships.

Lord, where I myself have sometimes been like a briar that pricked others with sharp words or impatience, change me by your Spirit into a fruitful tree that hands out your faithful love in a hungry world. Today I lay every sore place in my friendships and in my family at your feet. Where human supports have wavered, I thank you that your faithfulness reaches to the clouds.

Today I climb up to the watchtower of faith: I watch for you, I wait with quiet hope for you to act, and I rest in the sure knowledge: my God will hear me! In the name of Jesus Christ, my faithful Friend and Redeemer, Amen.

DAY 14

Who Is a God Like You? Sins Cast into the Depths of the Sea

SCRIPTURE

Micah 7:8–20

8 Do not rejoice over me, my enemy!
When I have fallen, I rise;
when I sit in darkness,
the LORD is light for me.
9 The rage of the LORD I will bear,
for I have sinned against him,
until he pleads my case
and brings about justice for me.
He will bring me out into the light;
I will see his righteousness.
10 And my enemy will see it,
and shame will cover her
who said to me: "Where is he, the LORD your God?"
My eyes will look on her;
now she will be trampled down
like mud in the streets.
11 A day for building your walls!
On that day the boundary will be pushed far out.
12 On that day they will come to you,
from Assyria and the cities of Egypt,
and from Egypt to the River,
from sea to sea and from mountain to mountain.
13 But the earth will become a desolation
because of those who live in it,
as the fruit of their deeds.
14 Shepherd your people with your staff,
the flock of your inheritance,
who live alone in a forest,
in the midst of a fruitful land;
let them graze in Bashan and Gilead
as in ancient days.
15 As in the days when you came out of the land of Egypt,
I will show him wonders.

16 Nations will see and be ashamed
of all their might;
they will lay a hand on their mouth;
their ears will be deaf.
17 They will lick dust like the snake,
like the creatures that crawl on the earth;
they will come trembling out of their strongholds;
to the LORD our God they will come in dread,
and they will fear you.
18 Who is a God like you,
who bears away guilt
and passes over rebellion
for the remnant of his inheritance?
He does not hold on to his anger for ever,
for he delights in faithful love.
19 He will again have compassion on us;
he will tread our guilt underfoot.
And you will cast all their sins
into the depths of the sea.
20 You will give truth to Jacob,
faithful love to Abraham,
as you swore to our fathers
from days of old.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With Micah 7:8–20 we reach the majestic closing chord of the whole book of Micah – and the last day of our fourteen-day journey. This passage is written in the form of a **prophetic liturgy** in which different voices take turns: first the repentant city of Zion speaks to her gloating enemy (vv. 8–10), then the prophetic promise of rebuilding rings out (vv. 11–13), fol-

lowed by the shepherd's prayer and God's answer (vv. 14–17), and finally the whole community of faith bursts into an overwhelming hymn of praise for God's forgiveness (vv. 18–20).

Notice the radical change in Zion's heart (vv. 8–9). In chapters 2 and 3 the leaders of Jerusalem denied their sin and said arrogantly: "*Is not the* LORD *in our midst? No evil will come upon us.*" (3:11). But here in chapter 7 we hear the voice of **true repentance**. Zion makes no more excuses: "*The rage of the* LORD *I will bear, for I have sinned against him*" (v. 9). And at the very moment the sinner stops defending himself and confesses his guilt before God, the Lord steps in as his **Advocate**. The same Lord who in Micah 1:2 stood as a witness against the peoples, and in 6:1–2 pleaded a case (*riv*) *against* his people, now in 7:9 takes up the case *for* his child ("*until he pleads my case*" – *yariv rivi* – יָרִיב רִיבִי) and leads her out of the dark dungeon into the light!

The book ends where it began – with Micah's own name. In verse 18 the prophet asks: "***Who is a God like you?***" In Hebrew this sounds like *mi el kamokha* – מִי אֵל כָּמוֹךָ – a direct play on the name **Micah** (Mi*kha*h, short for Mi*kha*yah: who is like the LORD?). It is also the title of this series. In chapter 1 no one was like the LORD in his **holy judgement** that makes the mountains melt; here in chapter 7 no one is like the LORD in his **fathomless forgiveness** that buries sins in the depths of the sea.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **When I have fallen, I rise (*ki nafalti qamti* – כִּי נָפַלְתִּי קָמְתִּי):** In the Hebrew poetry these two verbs stand right next to each other with no transition: "I have fallen – I have risen!" For the child of God a fall into sin or discipline is never the end of the story, because the LORD himself is his light in the darkness.
- **Shepherd with your staff – Carmel, Bashan and Gilead (v. 14):** In Micah 4:14 (English 5:1) the judge (ruler) of Israel was struck on the cheek with the staff (*shevet* – שֵׁבֶט), and in 6:9 the city bowed under the

disciplining rod (*matteh*). Now the staff becomes once again the **shepherd's staff of care** (cf. Psalm 23:4). The word *karmel* (כַּרְמֶל – orchard land; our translation: "*in the midst of a fruitful land*", though it is also the name of Mount Carmel), together with *Bashan* and *Gilead* (the rich pasture lands east of the Jordan which Assyria had already taken in 732 BC), symbolises the full restoration of the lost inheritance.

- **The trinity of sin and fourfold forgiveness (vv. 18–19):** See how thoroughly verses 18 and 19 deal with every facet of our guilt, using the same three key words that appear in Exodus 34:6–7: 1. **He bears away guilt (*nose' 'awon* – נֹשֵׂא עָוֹן):** *Nasa'* literally means **to lift up and carry away** (like the scapegoat on the great Day of Atonement, or the Lamb of God in John 1:29). It is the same verb as in verse 9: Zion says, "*The rage of the* LORD *I will bear*" – and God himself bears her guilt away. 2. **He passes over rebellion (*over 'al pesha'* – עֹבֵר עַל פֶּשַׁע):** The deliberate rebellion (*pesha'*) that brought on the judgement in Micah 1:5 is passed over by God in grace. 3. **He treads our guilt underfoot (*yikhbosh* – יִכְבֹּשׁ):** The verb *kavash* means to subdue an enemy under your feet and trample him. God treats our sins not merely as a debt on an account but as a tyrant whom he crushes under his feet! 4. **Into the depths of the sea (*bimtsulot yam* – בִּמְצֻלוֹת יָם):** Just as Pharaoh's chariots at the exodus from Egypt (cf. v. 15; Exodus 15:5) sank like a stone into the depths (*metsulot*) of the Red Sea, never to rise again, God drowns all our sins (*chatta't*) for ever in the ocean of his grace.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **True repentance turns God from our Judge into our Advocate.** As long as we cover and justify our sins, God stands against us; but the moment we, like Zion in verse 9, agree with God about our guilt, he himself steps in to defend our case against the accuser (cf. 1 John 1:9; 2:1).

2. **God's highest joy lies not in anger but in grace.** Verse 18 gives us a glimpse into the very depths of God's heart: *"He does not hold on to his anger for ever, for he delights in faithful love."* He **delights** (*chafets* – חָפֵץ) in **faithful love** (*chesed*). Judgement is God's "strange work" (Isaiah 28:21), but showing grace and covenant love (*chesed*) is his passionate joy!
3. **God's forgiveness is both complete and irreversible.** Our sins are not laid down on a shallow beach where tomorrow's low tide can wash them up again; they are cast into the *depths of the sea*. On the cross of Golgotha Jesus Christ took all our *'awon*, *pesha'* and *chatta't* upon himself (*nasa'*), crushed the power of sin under his feet (*kavash*), and blotted out the record of our debt for ever (Colossians 2:14–15).
4. **Our certainty rests on God's unbreakable covenant oath.** The last verse of the book (v. 20) anchors our future not in our own fickle faithfulness, but in the **truth (*emet*) and faithful love (*chesed*)** that God promised on oath to Abraham and Jacob (cf. Luke 1:72–73, where Zechariah, looking ahead to the coming of Jesus, clearly echoes this very verse).

Living It Out

At the end of our journey through Micah, chapter 7:8–20 leaves us with three life-changing truths for our everyday walk of faith.

First, verses 8 and 9 give us a powerful weapon against **the accusations of the enemy and our own feelings of guilt**. When you have stumbled, or are sitting in a dark season of discipline and consequences, the enemy (the "my enemy" of verses 8 and 10, the enemy of your soul) immediately whispers: *Look at you! Where is the* LORD *your God now? You have fallen too far to get up again*. Don't argue with the accuser about your own goodness. Do what Micah does: **confess your guilt honestly before God, and at the**

same time point to your Redeemer. Say boldly: *Yes, I have fallen, but by his grace I get up again! Even if I sit in the dark today, the* LORD *is my light, and he will plead my case.*

Second, the Jewish tradition of ***Tashlich*** (based on Micah 7:18–20, in which believers throw crumbs of bread into flowing water as a symbol of their sins) invites us to **stop "fishing" where God has buried our sins.** As the well-known Dutch Christian speaker and writer Corrie ten Boom once said: when God casts our sins into the deepest sea, he puts up a sign on the shore that reads, "*No fishing allowed!*" How often do we dive back in our minds into confessed sins from our past, only to punish ourselves with them all over again? If the holy God has trampled your sins under his feet through the blood of Jesus and thrown them into the deep sea, honour him by accepting his complete acquittal.

Finally, verse 18 connects with Micah 6:8. In 6:8 the Lord asked that *we* love *chesed* (merciful, faithful love). Why? Because in 7:18 we see that **God himself delights in *chesed*!** When we see how the Lord passes over our great rebellion and casts our guilt into the sea, our own hardness melts away. Whoever has truly stood beneath the cross of this God and cried out, "*Who is a God like you?*", cannot help but let the guilt of their neighbour sink into the sea of forgiveness as well.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- When you stumble spiritually or go through a dark time, do you let feelings of guilt and the accuser keep you in the mud, or do you cling to the confession of faith in verse 8: "*When I have fallen, I rise; when I sit in darkness, the* LORD *is light for me*"?
- Do you truly believe, deep down, that the Lord **delights in faithful love** (v. 18) – that he forgives *gladly* and with joy when you return to him – or do you still think of him as someone who forgives reluctantly and with a frown?

- Is there an old, already confessed sin or failure from your past that the Lord has long since cast into the "depths of the sea" (v. 19), but that you still keep trying to dredge up in your mind?
- Towards which person in your life is the Lord calling you today to show the same heart as verse 18: not to hold on to your anger, but to pass over an offence because God has forgiven you so much?

Prayer

> *Incomparable Lord, my God and my Redeemer – who is a God like you! At the end of this journey through the book of Micah I fall down at your feet in deep worship and wonder. You are the Holy One before whom the mountains melt like wax, and yet you are the Merciful One who finds deep joy in showing grace and bringing sinners home.*
>
> *Lord, when I sit in the darkness of my own failings and trials, I thank you that you yourself are my Light and my Advocate. Thank you that through the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ you have trampled the power of my sin under your feet and cast all my rebellion into the depths of the sea, where it will never rise against me again.*
>
> *Shepherd me today and all the days of my life with your shepherd's staff. Make my heart soft and generous in forgiving others, just as you have been towards me. Today I rest completely in your covenant faithfulness and your everlasting faithful love. To you belong all praise, honour and glory, now and for ever! Amen.*

The whole book of Micah

The complete text of Micah in the translation used in these devotionals.

Chapter 1

[1] The word of the LORD that came to Micah of Moresheth in the days of
Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah, kings of Judah, which he saw concerning
Samaria and Jerusalem.

[2] Hear, you peoples, all of you!
Listen, O earth, and all that fills it!
Let the Lord, the LORD, be a witness against you,
the Lord from his holy temple.
[3] For look: the LORD is coming out of his place;
he comes down and treads on the high places of the earth.
[4] The mountains melt beneath him,
and the valleys split open,
like wax before the fire,
like water poured down a slope.
[5] All this is for the rebellion of Jacob
and for the sins of the house of Israel.
What is the rebellion of Jacob?
Is it not Samaria?
And what are the high places of Judah?
Is it not Jerusalem?
[6] So I will make Samaria a heap of rubble in the open field,
a place for planting vineyards;
I will pour her stones down into the valley
and lay bare her foundations.
[7] All her carved images will be smashed,
all her wages will be burned with fire,
and all her idols I will make a desolation;
for from the wages of a prostitute she gathered them,
and to the wages of a prostitute they will return.
[8] Because of this I will lament and wail;

I will go stripped and naked;
I will make a lament like the jackals
and a mourning like the ostriches.
9 For her wounds are incurable;
it has come as far as Judah,
it has reached the gate of my people,
as far as Jerusalem.
10 In Gath do not tell it;
do not weep at all.
In Beth-leaphrah
roll yourself in the dust.
11 Pass on your way,
inhabitant of Shaphir, in nakedness and shame.
The inhabitant of Zaanan
has not come out.
The lament of Beth-ezel –
it will take from you its standing place.
12 For the inhabitant of Maroth
waits in anguish for good,
for evil has come down from the LORD
to the gate of Jerusalem.
13 Harness the chariot to the steed,
inhabitant of Lachish!
She was the beginning of sin for Daughter Zion,
for in you were found the rebellions of Israel.
14 Therefore you will give parting gifts
to Moresheth-gath;
the houses of Achzib will be a deceit
to the kings of Israel.
15 Once more I will bring the one who takes possession to you,
inhabitant of Mareshah;
as far as Adullam
the glory of Israel will come.
16 Make yourself bald and shave your head
for the children of your delight;

make your baldness as wide as the vulture's,
for they have gone from you into exile.

Chapter 2

[1] Woe to those who devise wickedness
and work evil on their beds!
In the light of morning they carry it out,
because it is in the power of their hand.
[2] They covet fields and seize them,
and houses, and take them away;
they oppress a man and his house,
a person and his inheritance.
[3] Therefore thus says the LORD:
Look, against this family I am devising evil,
from which you cannot remove your necks;
and you will not walk with heads held high,
for it will be a time of evil.
[4] On that day they will take up a taunt-song against you
and wail a bitter lament:
"It is done!" one says.
"We are utterly ruined!
He exchanges the portion of my people.
How he takes it away from me!
To the renegade he divides up our fields."
[5] Therefore you will have no one
to cast the measuring line by lot
in the assembly of the LORD.
[6] "Do not preach!" – so they preach.
"One should not preach about such things;
disgrace will not overtake us."
[7] Should this be said, house of Jacob:
"Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient?
Are these his deeds?"
Do my words not do good
to the one who walks uprightly?

[8] But lately my people has risen up as an enemy.
From off the garment you strip the cloak
from those who pass by in trust,
like men coming home from war.
[9] The women of my people you drive out,
each from the house she delights in;
from her little children you take away
my splendour for ever.
[10] Get up and go!
For this is not the resting place;
because of uncleanness it brings destruction,
a grievous destruction.
[11] If a man came walking in wind and falsehood
and lied: "I will preach to you about wine and strong drink!" –
he would be the preacher for this people.
[12] I will surely gather all of you, Jacob;
I will surely assemble the remnant of Israel.
I will put them together like sheep in a fold,
like a flock in the midst of its pasture;
they will be noisy with people.
[13] The one who breaks open goes up before them;
they break through, pass through the gate
and go out by it.
Their king passes on before them,
and the LORD at their head.

Chapter 3

[1] And I said:
Hear, please, you heads of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel!
Is it not for you to know justice?
[2] You who hate good and love evil,
who tear their skin from off them
and their flesh from off their bones;
[3] who eat the flesh of my people

and strip their skin from off them,
break their bones in pieces
and chop them up like meat for the pot,
like flesh in the cauldron.
4 Then they will cry out to the LORD,
but he will not answer them;
he will hide his face from them at that time,
because they have made their deeds evil.
5 Thus says the LORD concerning the prophets
who lead my people astray,
who, when they have something to bite with their teeth,
call out "Peace!",
but whoever puts nothing into their mouths,
against him they sanctify war:
6 Therefore it will be night for you, without vision,
and darkness for you, without divination.
The sun will go down on the prophets,
and the day will grow dark over them.
7 The seers will be ashamed
and the diviners disgraced;
they will all cover their lips,
for there is no answer from God.
8 But as for me, I am filled with power,
with the Spirit of the LORD,
with justice and with might,
to declare to Jacob his rebellion
and to Israel his sin.
9 Hear this, please, you heads of the house of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel,
who abhor justice
and twist everything that is straight,
10 who build Zion with blood
and Jerusalem with injustice!
11 Her heads judge for a bribe,
her priests teach for a price,

and her prophets divine for money;
yet they lean on the LORD and say:
"Is not the LORD in our midst?
No evil will come upon us."
12 Therefore, because of you,
Zion will be ploughed as a field,
Jerusalem will become heaps of ruins,
and the mountain of the house a wooded height.

Chapter 4

1 And it will come to pass in the last days
that the mountain of the house of the LORD
will stand firm as the highest of the mountains
and be lifted up above the hills,
and peoples will stream to it.
2 Many nations will come and say:
"Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD,
to the house of the God of Jacob,
so that he may teach us his ways
and we may walk in his paths."
For from Zion instruction will go out,
and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.
3 He will judge between many peoples
and settle disputes for mighty nations far away.
They will beat their swords into ploughshares
and their spears into pruning knives.
Nation will not lift up sword against nation,
and they will no longer learn war.
4 They will sit, each under his vine
and under his fig tree,
and no one will make them afraid;
for the mouth of the LORD of hosts has spoken.
5 For all the peoples walk,
each in the name of its god,
but we will walk in the name of the LORD our God

for ever and ever.
6 On that day – declares the LORD –
I will gather the lame
and assemble the outcast,
and the one on whom I brought evil.
7 I will make the lame a remnant,
and the one driven far away a mighty nation;
and the LORD will reign over them on Mount Zion
from now on and for ever.
8 And you, tower of the flock,
hill of Daughter Zion,
to you it will come:
the former dominion will come,
the kingdom of Daughter Jerusalem.
9 Now, why do you cry out so loudly?
Is there no king in you?
Has your counsellor perished,
that pain has seized you like a woman giving birth?
10 Writhe and push, Daughter Zion,
like a woman giving birth!
For now you will go out of the city
and live in the open field;
you will come as far as Babylon.
There you will be rescued;
there the LORD will redeem you
from the hand of your enemies.
11 And now many nations
have gathered against you,
who say: "Let her be defiled,
and let our eyes gloat over Zion!"
12 But they do not know the plans of the LORD,
and they do not understand his counsel:
that he has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor.
13 Get up and thresh, Daughter Zion!
For I will make your horn iron,

and your hoofs I will make bronze;
you will crush many peoples.
And I will devote their gain to the LORD,
their wealth to the Lord of all the earth.
14 Now gather your troops, daughter of troops!
A siege has been laid against us;
with the staff they strike the judge of Israel
on the cheek. (*English Bibles*: 5:1)

Chapter 5

1 But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah,
too small to be among the clans of Judah,
from you one will come out for me
to be ruler in Israel;
his origins are from of old,
from ancient days. (*English Bibles*: 5:2; *from here on add one to the verse number*)
2 Therefore he will give them up
until the time when she who is in labour has given birth;
then the rest of his brothers will return
to the children of Israel.
3 He will stand and shepherd
in the strength of the LORD,
in the majesty of the name of the LORD his God.
And they will dwell secure,
for now he will be great
to the ends of the earth.
4 And this one will be peace.
When Assyria comes into our land
and when he treads in our fortresses,
we will raise against him seven shepherds
and eight princes of men.
5 They will shepherd the land of Assyria with the sword,
and the land of Nimrod at its gates.
And he will rescue us from Assyria

when he comes into our land
and when he treads within our borders.
[6] And the remnant of Jacob will be
in the midst of many peoples
like dew from the LORD,
like showers on the grass,
which does not wait for a man
nor hope for the children of men.
[7] And the remnant of Jacob will be among the nations,
in the midst of many peoples,
like a lion among the animals of the forest,
like a young lion among the flocks of sheep,
which, if it passes through, tramples and tears,
and there is no one to rescue.
[8] Your hand will be lifted high over your adversaries,
and all your enemies will be cut off.
[9] And it will come to pass on that day – declares the LORD –
that I will cut off your horses from among you
and make your chariots perish.
[10] I will cut off the cities of your land
and tear down all your fortresses.
[11] I will cut off sorceries from your hand,
and you will have no more fortune-tellers.
[12] I will cut off your carved images
and your sacred pillars from among you,
and you will no longer bow down
to the work of your hands.
[13] I will uproot your Asherah poles from among you
and destroy your cities.
[14] And in anger and in wrath I will execute vengeance
on the nations that did not listen.

Chapter 6

[1] Hear, please, what the LORD says:
Get up, plead the case before the mountains,

and let the hills hear your voice!
2 Hear, you mountains, the case of the LORD,
you enduring ones, foundations of the earth!
For the LORD has a case against his people,
and with Israel he will argue it.
3 My people, what have I done to you?
How have I wearied you? Answer me!
4 For I brought you up from the land of Egypt,
and from the house of slaves I redeemed you;
and I sent before you
Moses, Aaron and Miriam.
5 My people, remember
what Balak king of Moab planned,
and what Balaam son of Beor answered him –
from Shittim to Gilgal –
so that you may know the righteous acts of the LORD.
6 With what shall I come before the LORD,
and bow down before God on high?
Shall I come before him with burnt offerings,
with calves a year old?
7 Will the LORD be pleased with thousands of rams,
with ten thousand rivers of oil?
Shall I give my firstborn for my rebellion,
the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul?
8 He has told you, O man, what is good,
and what the LORD seeks from you:
only to do justice,
to love faithful love,
and to walk humbly with your God.
9 The voice of the LORD calls out to the city –
and it is wisdom to see your name:
Hear the rod, and the one who appointed it!
10 Are there still in the house of the wicked
treasures of wickedness,
and the short measure that is cursed?

[11] Can I count anyone pure with wicked scales
and with a bag of deceitful weights?
[12] Her rich men are full of violence,
her inhabitants speak falsehood,
and their tongue is deceit in their mouth.
[13] So I too have begun to strike you,
to make you desolate because of your sins.
[14] You will eat, but not be satisfied,
and the hunger will be inside you;
you will put things aside, but not save them,
and what you save I will give to the sword.
[15] You will sow, but not reap;
you will tread olives, but not anoint yourself with oil,
and grapes for new wine, but not drink wine.
[16] The statutes of Omri are kept,
and all the practices of the house of Ahab,
and you walk in their counsels;
so I will make you a desolation,
and her inhabitants something to hiss at;
and you will bear the reproach of my people.

Chapter 7

[1] Woe is me! For I have become
like one gathering summer fruit,
like one gleaning after the grape harvest:
there is no cluster to eat,
no early fig that my soul longs for.
[2] The faithful one has perished from the land,
and there is no one upright among people.
They all lie in wait for blood;
each hunts his brother with a net.
[3] Their hands are on evil, to do it well:
the official asks, and the judge – for a payment;
and the great man speaks out the craving of his soul;
and so they weave it together.

4 The best of them is like a briar,
the most upright worse than a thorn hedge.
The day of your watchmen, your punishment, has come;
now their confusion will be.
5 Do not trust a friend,
do not rely on a close companion;
from her who lies in your embrace
guard the doors of your mouth.
6 For son treats father with contempt,
daughter rises up against her mother,
daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law;
a man's enemies are the people of his own house.
7 But as for me, I will watch for the LORD;
I will wait for the God of my salvation;
my God will hear me.
8 Do not rejoice over me, my enemy!
When I have fallen, I rise;
when I sit in darkness,
the LORD is light for me.
9 The rage of the LORD I will bear,
for I have sinned against him,
until he pleads my case
and brings about justice for me.
He will bring me out into the light;
I will see his righteousness.
10 And my enemy will see it,
and shame will cover her
who said to me: "Where is he, the LORD your God?"
My eyes will look on her;
now she will be trampled down
like mud in the streets.
11 A day for building your walls!
On that day the boundary will be pushed far out.
12 On that day they will come to you,
from Assyria and the cities of Egypt,

and from Egypt to the River,
from sea to sea and from mountain to mountain.
13 But the earth will become a desolation
because of those who live in it,
as the fruit of their deeds.
14 Shepherd your people with your staff,
the flock of your inheritance,
who live alone in a forest,
in the midst of a fruitful land;
let them graze in Bashan and Gilead
as in ancient days.
15 As in the days when you came out of the land of Egypt,
I will show him wonders.
16 Nations will see and be ashamed
of all their might;
they will lay a hand on their mouth;
their ears will be deaf.
17 They will lick dust like the snake,
like the creatures that crawl on the earth;
they will come trembling out of their strongholds;
to the LORD our God they will come in dread,
and they will fear you.
18 Who is a God like you,
who bears away guilt
and passes over rebellion
for the remnant of his inheritance?
He does not hold on to his anger for ever,
for he delights in faithful love.
19 He will again have compassion on us;
he will tread our guilt underfoot.
And you will cast all their sins
into the depths of the sea.
20 You will give truth to Jacob,
faithful love to Abraham,
as you swore to our fathers

from days of old.